

THE NINE LIVES OF ASHCAT

A Mystery of Hollowmere

SparkyGames

Adapted from the video game *The Nine Lives of Ashcat*.

This book, like the game it grew from, was made with substantial help from artificial intelligence. We think honesty about that is worth more than mystique.

All persons, cats, guilds, geese, and bureaucracies of death depicted herein are fictional. The Mere, in particular, does not exist, and would prefer you kept believing that.

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Prologue: The Night of the Kettle

Dusk over Hollowmere, and the lamps going up one by one, like the city buttoning its coat.

From the ridge of the Fish-Giver's roof I can see most of what matters: the chimney forests of the Shambles, the canals doing their slow grey thinking, the fog beginning its evening climb up from the Mere the way it always does, patient as rent. Somewhere below, a door slams. Somewhere else, a man says something unkind about a horse. The city, in other words, in working order.

She puts the kettle on when the lamps go up. I am punctual. She is predictable. The arrangement works, and has worked for fifteen years, which is longer than most marriages and every government.

Her name, for the record — because tonight of all nights the record matters — is Elspeth Vane. The city calls her the Needle of Hollowmere, mostly behind her back, always with respect. She is a witch, which in this city is a trade like any other: she sews. Wards, hems, bindings, the long invisible seams that keep a place from coming apart at its corners. Magic here is needlework. Anyone who tells you otherwise is selling candles.

And I am Ash. Her cat. Other titles have been proposed over the years — familiar, companion, mouser-in-residence, *that animal* — and I answer to none of them and come to all of them, provided there is a fire on.

Tonight calls for a gift. A vole, ideally. Voles say what flowers cannot.

* * *

There. Under the chimney pot. Fat, smug, unaware.

I go low. The tiles are still day-warm under my belly, and the wind is doing me the courtesy of blowing the wrong way for the vole and the right way for me. There is a red feeling that lives at the bottom of a cat, older than cities, older than names, and it comes up through me now like heat through a floor: the world narrowing to one point with fur on it.

Tonight the world is simple, and the world is *red*.

The vole makes its argument, which is brief, and mostly consists of running. I make mine. Mine is better. There is a scuffle among the chimney pots which I will describe, in the interest of dignity, as *professional*, and then it is over, and the vole has been acquired. Thoughtfully dead. Arranged neatly, carried gently, the way a gift ought to be.

She will say “not on the table,” and mean *thank you*. Fifteen years. The arrangement works.

I take the rooftop road toward home with the vole warm in my mouth and the evening going purple at its edges, and this is the last hour of my life in which the world is simple, and I spend it thinking about a sunbeam I remember from March. I want that noted. Whatever else the record says of me, let it say I was happy, and did not know it, which is the only way anyone ever is.

* * *

Below me now: the Shambles, shut for the night, stalls sleeping under canvas. Eight bells sound from the tower — the whole count, one to eight, dropped into the fog like coins into a well.

There used to be a ninth bell. There is no ninth any more. Nobody remembers when that changed, and nobody finds that strange, and the not-finding-it-strange is itself the strange part, if you are the sort of creature who keeps accounts. Cats keep accounts. It is most of what we do, between meals.

And between two chimneys, strung across the dark like a hair caught in a comb: a thread of silver light. Humming.

Everything alive trails a thread, if you have the eyes for it. Threads run through this city thicker than smells — out of windows, along

gutters, wound around wrists and doorposts and the necks of sleeping children — the underlay of everything, which she calls the Weft. Witches stitch with them. Cats only see them. Hers I know by heart, the way you know a voice through a wall: silver, with a particular twist to it, like handwriting.

This one is silver too. And it is nobody's I know.

I did not chase the silver thread. A cat of fifteen years' standing, carrying a gift, does not go haring off across the roofline after every unexplained piece of glimmer the night hangs up. I looked at it. I considered it. I made a small note in the ledger of things that are wrong tonight, and I went on my way, and the lie I told myself about *not wanting* to chase it weighed nothing at all.

Almost nothing.

* * *

Street level, Needle Lane, and the fog rolls up from the Mere to meet me, and the shadows deepen — deep enough to wear, if you know how. A cat in proper shadow is a rumor. I have been a rumor most of my life.

Something small and hungry climbs out of the gutter.

A gutter-wisp: bottle-sized, bottle-shaped, a swallowed lantern of a thing, all glow and appetite. They eat small lies. It is one of the tidier arrangements of the night-side — the city breathes out its little dishonesties and the wisps Hoover them up, and everyone pretends this is not happening, which feeds them further. This one heard mine. The one about not wanting to chase the thread. It has come to collect.

I would like to tell you I handled it with grace. What happened is that a cat and a lit appetite had a disagreement in a foggy gutter, and the fog was on my side, and after a certain amount of undignified geometry the wisp reconsidered its position on my honesty and went back down the drain, dimmer.

I sat a moment in the fog and put my coat back in order, and that was when I noticed the quiet.

No pigeons.

Understand: pigeons are never quiet. Quiet is against their religion. The roosts over Needle Lane run a continuous parliamentary session

of complaint and scandal from dusk until dawn, and I have slept under that noise my whole life the way sailors sleep under weather. It was not there. The roofline sat against the sky, empty as a shelf.

The ledger of things wrong tonight was becoming a page with writing on both sides.

* * *

The lamps on Needle Lane are lit in the wrong order.

You would have to live here to see it. The Lamplighters walk a sequence, every night, the same way a woman signs her name the same way: third lamp, then first, then the one by the pump, a route so old it has worn a groove in the evening. The order is the point — I have heard one of them say so, on a doorstep, to an apprentice: *we light them in an order, lad, and the order is the stitch*. Tonight the lane is lit like a mouth of broken teeth, dark-bright-dark-dark-bright, a signature forged by someone who has only ever seen it written.

The Lamplighters never miss. The dog at Number Twelve is awake — I can smell him being awake — and he does not bark, which he has never once in his loud and tedious life failed to do.

And halfway down the lane, the fog stops being fog.

It has sleeves. It has a collar. It has the shape of a person who is not in it — a coat filled with occupied air — and every cut thread on this street is running toward it, sliding through the dark like water finding a drain. That is when I see what has been done to the lane: the threads are *cut*. Window-threads, door-threads, the little tethers of household luck — snipped, all of them, and drifting to this one standing shape, which is gathering them in.

They have a name, things like this. Rag-wraiths: clothes whose owners are missing. Not dead — *missing*. The distinction matters to the things themselves, I am told, and it is about to matter a great deal to me.

It turns what it has instead of a face toward me. Whatever unpicked these lamps is still at its work, and I am standing in its light.

I fought it. I will say this once, plainly, because what came later has made the memory expensive: I put every nature I own against

it, the red and the green and the black, and I even spent the pale — the moonlight-colored strength that is hers, that she stitched into me, that I carry and cannot make — and none of it was enough, and I am not ashamed. It was above my weight and it knew it. In the end I did the intelligent thing, which the stories never put in: I slipped away. Three streets before I stopped, and I stopped because my legs decided it, not me.

Nothing followed. Nothing was missing. Ash: one. The weather: nothing.

And yet. It was not hunting me. All that size, all that gathered-up stolen thread, and it spent none of it on a cat. It was *working*. Whatever it was doing to that street, I interrupted it about as much as a fly interrupts a window.

I did not know yet what work it was about. I have had a long time since to learn, and the learning is this book.

* * *

Her window is ahead now.

Dark.

Her window is never dark.

Two ways home from here. The long way passes the Lamplighters' hall — and whatever silenced the lamps went wrong there first; the professional in me knows it the way a tongue knows the broken tooth. The fast way is over the fences. Now.

I am going to tell you what I chose, and then I am going to spend the rest of my lives wondering about it.

I took the long way. Eleven minutes, perhaps twelve. Because a cat is a creature of routes and the route had a wrongness at the head of it, and because fifteen years of her voice in my ear said *look before you leap, Ash, it is the entire difference between brave and stupid*. I told myself she was out. I told myself the kettle was late, the lamp unlit, some errand, some visit. The wisps, if any were near, will have eaten well on that.

The hall stood open. Door wide, ladders racked, coats on their pegs. The kettle on their little stove was cold — and a guild hall's kettle is never cold; it is the heart the place beats with. Forty men

and women walk out of this room every evening and light a city, and the room was holding its breath, and nobody was in it.

Caught on a lamp-hook by the door, glinting where it had snagged: a thread of silver.

Her stitching. I would know it under floodwater. She was here — tonight, in this room, my witch, who has not walked out on an evening in years. Why was she *here*?

I ran then. Out of the hall and eleven streets home, and I do not remember eight of them. The fog thinning near the Mere. Ordinary houses, ordinary gates, a cat crossing an ordinary city at an unreasonable speed. Her street. Her gate. Her drainpipe, the one I have used nine hundred times, and up, and in through the workroom window — a door has never once been an obstacle; it is, however, always an insult —

and the house is doing the wrong thing with sound.

A kettle, screaming. And nobody going to it.

* * *

The workroom first, and the workroom is wrong. The threads on the walls — her lifetime of small tied workings, the hems of the house, forty years of her work hung like a garden — cut. All of them. Hanging like torn hems, every single one snipped at the same height, cleanly, as if by someone *tidying*.

The parlor door stands open, and I do not go through it. Not yet. I am a cat who has learned to look at a room before he is in it. I stop at the threshold, low, and I look.

Something is standing in the parlor doorway on the far side, wearing the room.

It is person-shaped the way a coat on a hook is person-shaped, and it is made of *her* threads — it has been pulling them out of the walls and putting them *on*, winding forty years of her work around its absence like a man dressing in another man's clothes. Where the light of the hearth should catch a face there is a weave, still moving, still settling, thread finding thread with a sound like the smallest rain.

It is still working. It does not stop when it sees me.

That is the part I will keep, of everything that night: it looked at me — whatever it looks with — and it *decided I was not an interruption*, and it went back to its work.

Every hair I have is standing up. Good. Let them.

I went for it. Of course I went for it. She was somewhere past that doorway and the thing between us was wearing her wards, and there is a red feeling at the bottom of a cat older than sense. I remember the first spring off the floorboards. I remember the weave turning, unhurried, and a sleeve coming around like the boom of a ship. I remember the pale strength going out of me in one bright useless flare — *spend it*, her voice said, from fifteen years of lessons, *spend everything, it is not for keeping* — and I spent everything, and it was not enough, and the room went sideways, and then the cold came up through the floor in a way that floors do not do.

I want to tell you dying hurts. It would make better telling. What it does is *leave*: the cold goes first, then the noise, then the part of you that was worried about the noise. What is left over found itself standing in a corridor that was all filing and no building, under a ceiling too far up to be a ceiling, in a light the color of four in the morning.

Nothing hurt. I found this deeply suspicious.

A desk. A lamp. A queue of one, and the one was me.

The being behind the desk was thin the way a ruled line is thin, translucent at the cuffs, with spectacles that had given up asking to be needed. He did not look up. Around him, shelves went away in every direction that shelves can go, and some that they cannot, all of them full, every folder tied with grey ribbon.

“Name?”

“Ashcat,” I said. “Of Needle Lane.” It seemed a night for the full formal.

“Needle Lane.” Something moved behind the spectacles that was almost interest. “Yes. We have had a busy evening from Needle Lane.”

He wrote. The pen made the sound of winter. Then he reached the column that mattered, and stopped.

“Nine allotted.” He said it to the paper, not to me. He turned the sheet over, as though the back of it might explain; the back of it did not. “I have not filed a nine since I was at a much smaller

desk. Vane's familiar." A pause you could have hung a coat on. "One spent."

He did not say whose the busy evening was. I did not ask. Not there. There are rooms where questions are expensive, and every whisker I own said this was the most expensive room in the world.

"The arrangement, since it is your first," said the Clerk. "Deaths are appointments. Tonight, you had one." He said it without cruelty, the way a man reads weather. "Arrive dead *without* an appointment and you will be refused at this desk — we are a court, not a revolving door. A true death — the kind you will always see coming — costs a life, and after the first, the Toll. Any other defeat is refused and returned. The first visit is complimentary. Do consider it a courtesy rather than a habit."

The stamp came down. It was, I noticed, a paw print. Neither of us remarked on this.

The stairs up are longer than the fall down. They always are.

* * *

Hearing came back first. Floorboards under one cheek. The smell of cold hearth. Four paws — count them — four. Whatever had been standing in the doorway was not standing in the doorway.

Get up, Ash.

The parlor.

Elsbeth in her chair. The light gone out of her hands.

...

The kettle was still screaming. It had been screaming this whole time, and I did not hear it until now. She hates it when it does that.

I took it off the fire. One paw, on the handle, the way I had watched her do it ten thousand times from the hearthrug. It took three tries. Nobody will ever know.

And then the house was quiet, and there was nothing else to take off any fire.

I got up on the arm of her chair, which I am not allowed to do, and nobody told me to get down. Her hands were folded in her lap,

and her face was not frightened, and not surprised, and not anything — the needle gone from it, the thread gone from it. Between the kettle boiling and the kettle screaming, any professional will tell you, is no time at all. Whoever did this to her did it *fast*, faster than any needle honestly goes, and did it in her own parlor, in her own light, between one breath of steam and the next.

Fifteen years. Every evening. She always came to the window.

I do not know how to be a cat that nobody is expecting.

I stayed on the arm of the chair while the fog pressed its face to the glass, and I will not tell you how long, because I do not know, and a cat is not obliged to keep time for anyone. At some point I found myself looking at the sewing table. Her red kerchief lay on it, folded — washed that morning, waiting to go back around her neck, where it had lived so long it was less a garment than a fact of her.

I put my head through it. Nobody tied it. It stays.

The thread at my chest — the one that was always hers, the tether every familiar wears, silver with that particular handwriting twist — cut. Of course. Cut like everything in this house was cut.

Not quite.

One strand left. Thin as spite. Running out from under the window, over the sill where her geraniums used to argue with the slugs, down into the fog, into the city.

I looked at it a long time. Outside, eight bells rang somewhere, and no ninth.

Then that is where we are going.

Part I

Wax and Wick

Chapter 1

The Carrying and the Wake

Three witches came at first light.

They did not knock. Witches do not knock at a house where a witch has died; a knock asks a question, and the house has already answered it. The door opened to Mother Cardew's hand the way furniture obeys the very old, and behind her came two young ones I did not know, one carrying folded linen, undyed — the only clean thing left in the room — and one carrying nothing but her own held breath.

I was on the arm of the chair. I had been on the arm of the chair all night. I did not get down.

Cardew is the eldest of the Witches' Circuit, which is nine seats of working witches, or was; it is eight now, though no one had said so aloud yet in that room. She is small and grey and folded, like something kept a long time in a drawer, and her eyes went around the parlor once, at working speed, and I watched her see everything. The cut threads. The cold kettle sitting off the fire, which nobody could account for and nobody asked about. Elspeth.

They lifted her the way you lift someone who might wake. That is the thing I will allow them, all three, forever: they were witches of the Circuit and she was the Needle and there is politics even in a parlor, but they lifted her like a sleeping woman, and the young one who had been carrying her own breath let it go, once, in the doorway, in a small ragged sound she will be embarrassed about for

years. I hope she reads this. It was the correct sound.

At the doorway, with the linen and its burden through it, Cardew stopped. She looked back at the walls, at forty years of workings hanging cut and dead at one tidy height, and she said:

“Who did this to the room.”

It was not a question. Burglars take things. Nothing in this house was taken — not the silver thimbles, not the bolt of moon-colored cloth worth a bargeman’s year, not the rings on the hand of the woman in the chair. Somebody had come into the Needle’s own parlor and *unpicked* it, and left everything of value except the value.

And then Cardew was looking at me.

Everyone else was looking at the floor. That is what people do around a dead witch’s cat: they look at the floor, because a familiar who has outlived his witch is a piece of grief with legs and no one wants to catch its eye. Cardew looked straight at me, the way you look at a colleague, and waited.

I had one chance to be taken seriously, and I knew it. A cat who yowls is comforted. A cat who performs is petted. I sat up on the chair arm, and I told it — all of it, in order, the way she taught me anything worth saying should go: the lamps lit wrong, the pigeons silent, the hall open and empty and its kettle cold, her silver thread on the lamp-hook, the fog with sleeves, the threads of the street running toward it like water to a drain. The workroom. The parlor doorway. The shape wearing the room, still working, that looked at me and decided I was not an interruption.

Cats can speak to those who trouble to listen. Most people do not trouble; it takes patience, and a willingness to be corrected. Cardew listened the whole way through without moving, and the two young witches stood in the doorway holding the morning open, and when I finished — *a shape wearing her work* — the old woman was quiet for a long moment.

Then she said, quieter, to nobody: “Again.”

She put the word down like something she had not meant to be holding. And I filed it, because *again* means *before*, and before means a pattern, and a pattern means the thing that killed my witch has habits, and things with habits can be found.

At the door, with her girls and their burden already in the lane, she turned once more.

“It has happened twice before,” she said. “Both times a stitcher. Both times nobody looked. I am too old and too watched. You are neither.” A pause. “Mind the room, cat. Rooms remember what people miss.”

Then they were gone into the fog with her, and the house was mine, and it was nobody’s.

* * *

I minded the room.

I went over it the way she went over a hem: slowly, twice, against the nap. A cat’s advantages in an investigation are these — we are low, we are patient, we are invisible to people who believe importance has a minimum height, and we have a nose that keeps better records than the Hollow Court. The parlor smelled of cold hearth and geranium and her — I will not write about that part — and, under everything, faint as a fingerprint on glass, of something that did not belong: pond-bottom. Old rope. Patient water. The Mere has a smell, and the Mere does not come up to Thimblefield, and it had been in this room.

And under the window, where the curtain hem brushes the boards, I found the candle stub.

Beeswax. Burned an inch down and pinched out, and stamped near the base with the mark of the bee: the Chandlers’ Guild, who hold the monopoly on every honest light in this city and several of the dishonest ones. Understand what that stub was doing in that room: nothing. It had no business existing there. Elspeth burned tallow her whole life — good witch-made tallow, smoky and stubborn like her — and she called beeswax *the rich man’s smell* and would not have it in the house. Somebody else’s light was in this room. Somebody stood at this window, in the dark of my witch’s parlor, and burned a fine wax candle down one inch — which is about an hour, as any cat who has slept beside a flame can tell you — and pinched it out, and did not trouble to take it away.

An hour. Somebody *waited* here, in the dark, comfortable, unhurried, while the kettle heated. In a parlor whose wards had stood forty years, and stood no more.

I sat with the stub between my paws while the light came up grey in the windows, and I began, formally, the way she began a working, with a naming of parts.

Item: a silver thread on a lamp-hook in an emptied hall. She was there, the night she died, and I did not know why, and hall-kettles do not go cold on their own.

Item: a street of cut threads, and a thing wearing them, that worked and did not hunt.

Item: quiet pigeons. Bought quiet or frightened quiet, but quiet has a price either way, and prices leave receipts.

Item: an hour of beeswax, pinched out, stamped with the bee.

Item: the word *again*.

Item: one strand of her, thin as spite, running out under the window, into the city. Mine now. My inheritance, along with the pale strength I carry and cannot make, and this house, and the arrangement of my entire life, cancelled.

The pale wants explaining, once, so the rest of this account can spend it without stopping. A cat runs on four strengths: the red, which is the hunt; the green, which is patience; the black, which is the long watch and the soft foot. Those three are mine the way teeth are mine — spend them and they grow back with meat and sleep. The fourth is the pale, moonlight-colored, and the witches call it plainly Moonlight: it is memory made spendable, it pays the prices the other three cannot, and no cat makes his own. Mine is hers — she stitched it into me — and spending it has never once felt like spending something of mine.

On the chimney breast above the mantel there is a cork board where she pinned the city's wants: little notes in little hands, *Mistress Vane, the churn's gone sour-hearted; Needle, the gate wards, before Lady's Day if you can*. Requests for her needle from a city that had no idea what it had. I got up on the mantel — I am allowed on the mantel; I have always been allowed on the mantel, that was the treaty of the second year — and I looked at that board a long time.

Then I knocked her pincushion off the shelf, took the longest pin in my teeth, and pinned the candle stub to the board, dead center.

My whole job used to be: be somewhere warm at the correct time. All right, then. New job.

* * *

They gave her to the tide at the turn of the evening, because the tide is the only thing in Hollowmere that has never been bribed.

That is the custom for witches here, and no one day-side troubles to know it, so I will tell it: no grave, no fire. A witch's work is thread, and thread must be tied off, not buried. They sew the shroud shut over her in her own stitch — the dead woman's own pattern, worked by whoever loved or owed her most — and they give her to the water at slack tide, and the sea unpicks what it is owed at its own pace, which is the only honest interest rate in the city.

The quay at the Shambles' edge was fuller than I had expected and emptier than she deserved. The Lamplighters sent four — everyone the hall has left, I would understand later, and understanding it later is a stone I still carry. They stood in a row with their ladders shouldered like rifles, and their lamps lit at half-wick, which is their mourning. The Magpie Exchange sent a bird I did not yet know, black and white and watchful on a bollard, with one respectful button laid on the stones before her. There were cats on the roofline, a dozen at least, sitting the way we sit at funerals, which is exactly the way we sit anywhere else; grief is nobody's business but the griever's. And the Chandlers' Guild sent one man, early, in very good black, standing precisely where he could be seen being sorry.

I noted him. The board on the chimney breast noted him.

The rite is the seam. Mother Cardew took the bone needle and the grey thread, and began the shroud's last seam in Elspeth's own pattern — and four stitches in, she stopped.

She stood there on the quay with the linen raised in her unsteady hands, an old woman in front of a city, and I watched her courage fail in a way I would not wish on an enemy. "I don't know her hand," she said. Quietly. To the linen. "Sixty years, and I don't know her hand."

Nobody moved. The tide turned underneath us — you can feel it through stone, through the pads of your feet, the moment the sea changes its mind — and the seam stood open four stitches, and the Needle of Hollowmere lay waiting on her bier for somebody who knew her stitch.

I have watched those hands from a windowsill every evening of my

life. Through fog, through frost-flowers, through my own reflection: the needle down, the thread drawn, the little tug at the end of each stitch like a word ending. I know the hand better than I know my own name — which she also gave me, so it comes to the same thing.

I got up onto the bier.

Somebody started forward to stop me — some notion of decency, a cat on a shroud — and Cardew said, “Let him,” in a voice that ended the subject for a generation.

I will not pretend my part was neat. A cat is not built for needle-work: I pushed the bone needle with a paw, drew the thread in my teeth, and the first stitch took me three tries, like the kettle, and nobody will ever know that either, except that I am writing it here, so now everyone will, and I find I do not mind. The pattern was in me the way routes are in me. Her hand, remembered by my whole body at once. Down, through, draw, tug — *a word ending* — and again, along the linen, while the tide stood slack and the lamps burned at half-wick and a row of cats on a warehouse roof watched a colleague work.

The seam closed. The tide took her without discussion, the way she would have wanted — no speeches, no splash, the grey linen going down through the grey water until it was a paleness, and then a memory, and then the sea seeing to its accounts.

One lamplighter forgot not to salute.

Then Mother Cardew did the thing for which I will forgive her everything else, always. In front of the guild delegates and the roofline and the man in very good black, she bent down — it cost her; I heard her knees pay it — and she tied a small grey knot into the thread at my chest, where the whole Weft could see it. A favor-knot: a debt, formal and visible, the real currency of the night-side. The old woman put her debt on record to a cat.

“A debt,” she said. “Mine. You will know when to spend it.”

And then, walking me back up the quay while the crowd made itself busy elsewhere, low, for my ears alone:

“It has happened twice before. Both times a stitcher. Both times nobody looked — the Circuit closed the files, and I signed the closing, and that is my portion of this and I will carry it. I am too old and too watched to open them again.” She stopped at the sea-wall and looked at the water a while. “You are neither. You were her ninth,

you know. She would never say what she meant by keeping count. Find who did this, cat, and I will hold what doors I can.”

Ninth. I filed the word next to *again*, in the drawer of things said to me that were heavier than the sayer knew.

* * *

Home, then, to a house with nobody in it.

Night had come down while the city walked back from the water. The lamps went up along her street — most of them; two dark, and I checked the ledger in my chest before I could stop myself — and I came in through the workroom window and sat in the dark parlor among the cut threads, and let the house be quiet at me.

The kettle sat where I had left it, off the fire, on the cold hearth-stone. And I found that of everything in the room — the empty chair, the cut walls, the shroud-grey light — the kettle was the wrongest thing, because a kettle off the fire is a kettle *finished*, and nothing here is finished. Nothing here has even begun.

I went up to the board on the chimney breast. The candle stub hung from its pin, throwing its little shadow. Beside it now I set the things the day had brought, each on its own pin, in a cat's tidy row: a thread of grey shroud-linen, for the two stitchers dead before her, whom nobody looked for. A gull feather from the quay, for the man in very good black who came early to be seen. And through the loop of it, where I could reach it with my eyes from the hearthrug, the end of the one uncut strand — hers, mine — still running out under the window into the city, patient as only thread is patient.

Somewhere out there was a shape that wore my witch's work like a coat. Somewhere nearer, probably, was whoever lit its way with an hour of fine wax and pinched the flame out afterward, tidily, the way you put away a tool you mean to use again.

Again.

I slept that night on the hearthrug, because the chair was not mine to fill, and I dreamed of her table years ago, a chart of the harbor wall half-sewn under lamplight, and a much smaller cat asleep on the middle of it, deployed as a paperweight, and her voice above me somewhere, amused, saying something I could not hear yet.

I woke with my paws working at the rug, stitching nothing, in her hand.

In the morning I went to find the Magpie.

Chapter 2

The Thread Itself

I said I went to find the Magpie in the morning. That was true, but it was the second true thing. The first was the thread.

It had not gone anywhere in the night. That is the property of thread which makes it better company than people: it waits. The one strand nobody cut still ran out from under the window, silver going grey where it crossed the sill's shadow, and out into a city that walked through it all day without feeling so much as a cobweb. I sat under the window and recalled her teaching, delivered over fifteen years in the tone of a woman talking to herself who knows perfectly well she is being overheard: *magic is needlework, Ash. The Weft is every thread of everything, crossing. To follow a thread you do not pull it — pulling tells the far end. You lay a paw on it, lightly, and you let it tell you which way it is cold.*

I put a paw on the line. It was cold toward the city. I went the way it was cold.

The strand ran the rooftops, and it ran them the clean way — chimney to chimney, along ridgelines, over the one plank bridge between the tannery and the ropewalk that even I use only on confident days. Follow a thing's route and you learn the thing. Whoever owned the far end of this thread knew Hollowmere the way I know it: not the streets, which anyone can learn, but the *overstreets*, the roof-roads, the ways that require you to be small and sure-footed and unbothered by heights. I made a note in the ledger, and the note read: *it travels like a cat*, and I did not like the note, so I turned the page.

Halfway across the Shambles' roofline I found the thread being robbed.

A gutter-wisp — fat, this one, prosperous — had wound itself around the strand where it sagged between two chimneys, and it was *drinking*: sipping the faint hum off the silver the way they sip lies out of the air. Not trespass. Grave-robbing. That hum was the last of her moving in the world, and I am not able to write down what I did to that wisp, because a report should be dispassionate, and there was nothing dispassionate in it. It went back down its drain unlit. The hum came back to the thread, faint, like a tune through a wall.

The thread dropped to street level at the roofline's end, ran along Needle Lane's gutter — past the wrong lamps, past Number Twelve, where the dog watched me pass in a silence we had both agreed never to discuss — and then it turned, and ran straight for the Mere.

And the fog stood up to meet it.

The Mere fog is not the river fog. River fog is weather; it has somewhere else to be. The Mere fog comes up the streets at its own pace, and it does not disperse so much as *decline to leave*, and the lane it occupied that morning was occupied wall to wall, a grey so thick the buildings on either side became opinions. Every window in it dark. Every thread in it slack. The strand ran into that fog low and taut, like a rope into deep water.

There was no fighting through it, because there was nothing to fight — only losing the line to be done, and I did not intend to lose the line. So I did the crossing the way she taught me the city must sometimes be done: by paying. A cat's natures are a purse, if you keep them right. Patience — the green — bought me the waiting at each curb while the fog breathed, and near the middle of the lane I felt, for the first time in my life, the bottom of that purse — not empty, but findable; the black bought me the stretches where being seen felt suddenly like a bad idea, though I saw no one; and twice, at crossings where the cold came up through my feet with that pond-bottom patience I had smelled in her parlor, I spent a little of the pale — her Moonlight, the wild strength that pays any price asked of it — and the cold drew back from me like a tide deciding I was not yet due. I came out the far side of the fog with wet whiskers, an intact line, and the firm intention of never telling anyone how fast my heart had been going.

The thread ran three more streets, down the terraces, and out onto the sea-wall at the Mereside edge.

And stopped.

Mid-air. Over the water. A cat's height above the black glass of the Mere, the strand ran out past the wall, thinned to a hair, and ended — not frayed, not worn, not melted in the manner of workings that fail. *Cut*. One clean bite, on a slant, the way scissors leave silk. I stood on the sea-wall with my paw on the last of her and looked at that ending a long time.

Understand what it meant. Almost nothing can see a thread. Of the things that can, almost none can touch one, and of those, almost none can cut one clean — her own wards took her forty years and a bone needle to tie and untie. Whoever went out over that water had seen the strand following them, had known it for what it was, and had turned and cut it *one clean stroke*, the way you or I would bite through a trailing string. And they had done it out over open water, where nothing walks.

The Mere lay flat as a ledger to the horizon-fog. Black water; the drowned thing under it that day-side children are told is a story and night-side children are told to stop asking about; the oldest resident, the patient one, sewn shut below the surface by a working I would learn the price of far too late. The fog on the far shore held its shapes the way it always does, and one of the shapes, for a moment, was the size of a man, and then was not, and I am a professional, and I wrote it down anyway.

So the thread was not a road. Very well. It was still an answer, and it was this: the killer reads the Weft, travels the overstreets, cuts clean, and did not want to be followed across the water. A trail closed on purpose is a trail worth money — and things worth money have a fence, and the Shambles keeps the best fence in the city.

Which brings me, second, to the Magpie.

* * *

The trouble with visiting the Magpie Exchange is that you must bring something, and the trouble with bringing something, if you are a cat, is that you have no pockets — or rather, you have nine,

but I did not intend to spend the contents of my shadow on an introduction. So I did the thing I had been circling since dawn and not doing: I went to her workbox, and I took her second-best thimble.

The second-best. The best is silver, and it stays where her fingers left it, and that is a rule of the new arrangement of the world, and the rule holds. The second-best is brass, worn through at the crown from four decades of the needle's little kiss, worth nothing to anyone who did not watch it work. I carried it to the Shambles in my own mouth, which is how a cat without hands demonstrates that a thing is being carried *on purpose*, and the whole way there it clicked gently against my teeth like a small tame ghost.

The Shambles after hours is my favorite kind of city: canvas and rope-creak and the day's fish-smell settling like sediment, lanes just wide enough for a barrow and exactly wide enough for me. The Exchange keeps no sign. It keeps a bird.

Brindle was on her perch above the stall shutters, doing the thing magpies do that looks like idleness and is inventory. Black and white with that oil-slick green in the wing, one eye on the lane, one on the ledger only she can see. I had seen her at the wake, on the bollard, with her respectful button. She watched me come the length of the lane with the thimble in my teeth and said, before I had set it down:

"You are the witch's cat."

"Was," I said.

She did not say sorry. She turned her head the other way round to look at me again, which in a bird is consideration, and she said, "Hm," in the tone of an appraiser finding the hallmark genuine, and I liked her enormously and permanently.

Business, then. I set the thimble on her counting-board and told her what I wanted to buy: last night but one, Needle Lane, who or what went along it, and anything the lane's gutters had yielded since. Information is the Exchange's true stock; the buttons are a courtesy the trade extends to itself. Brindle looked at the thimble a long time. She did not touch it.

"Payment comes in kinds," she said. "That one is the wrong kind. That one is grief, pet, and I do not fence grief; it only ever comes back on the fencer." She hopped once along the rail. "But work, now. Work I will take. My back alley has grown three nights of wisps — something has them fat and bold this season, and my stock glimmers,

and wisps drink glimmer when the lies run short. Clear my alley and we will talk like professionals.”

So I worked. It took the fat end of the night. Her alley had five of them, coiled in the shutter-slats and the drain-mouths like lit worms in an apple, and the work was low and quiet and mostly patience: you cannot rush a wisp out of a rich alley, you must make the alley expensive — a guard here, a cuff there, a cat plainly willing to spend the whole night being unprofitable to drink near. The last and fattest came out of the downspout at the greyest hour and made its argument, which had lights in it, and I declined the argument, and the alley was quiet.

Brindle watched the whole thing from her rail, upside down part of the time, which I chose not to notice.

“You’re not useless,” she said, at dawn. “That’s the whole interview.”

Then she told me what I had bought. A cart on Needle Lane, the night of it — late, unlit, wheels wrapped, and *wax on the wind of it*, she said, wax and something under the wax, pond-water and old rope. Twice along the lane, her pickers had it: up from the city riding light, and down toward the Mere riding heavy, the wrapped wheels telling the stones what the driver would not. I filed that as she said it — heavy toward the water, light away from it — and I could make nothing of it, and filed it anyway. No pigeons to raise the roosts about it, of course. Of course. And the lane’s gutters had yielded to her pickers, two mornings since, exactly one thing worth a shelf: a scrap of paper, cart-docket shaped, that a gull had beaten her to and a boy had beaten the gull to, and the boy sold to the Exchange for a licorice knot — *consigned, Needle Lane, night of*; and the consignee line scratched out. Scratched, mind. Not blank. Somebody drove a cart down an unlit street and then did not want to have been the sort of person who had.

She took the thimble at last — “for holding, pet, not for keeping; redeem it any dawn” — and she held it a moment longer than trade requires, and turned her head away, and that is as far as a magpie’s condolences go, and further than most people’s.

I went home along the roofline with a docket-scrap folded into my shadow and the following entry in the ledger: *the night had a cart, the cart had wax, the wax has a guild, and somebody is ashamed of*

the delivery. On the chimney-breast board, the candle stub gained a neighbor.

* * *

I lost. In her parlor, on the night, against the thing that wore the room — I lost. It came into her house and it did not even *hurry*. And every plan I had made since — the thread, the fence, the docket — ran on ahead of me to the same place and waited there with folded arms: sooner or later I would stand in front of that shape again, and on the current arithmetic it would take everything I am, a second time, at its leisure, while it worked.

So I decided to get better. Deliberately. Like a person. Instead of waiting to be improved by events.

I trained against the goose.

The Watch goose lives behind the tannery and guards six gardens' worth of back-run under a chain of office nobody remembers issuing it, and it has never lost an argument in its life — which is precisely what made it worth arguing with. Her rule, from the windowsill years: *the difference between brave and stupid is about four seconds of looking*. So I looked. Four seconds and more. I watched what the goose *did* — not the hissing, which is theater, but the feet, the weight, the neck's coiled bookkeeping — and I went in low and I lost, and looked, and lost, and looked, and on the fourth argument I did not lose, and left the garden unhissed-at, walking, which no cat in living memory has done.

I trained against the dog at Number Twelve — eleven feet of chain and a standing offer to discuss territory, an offer I had declined daily for years. I accepted the meeting. Slower, that one; a dog is honest the way weather is honest, and the lesson a dog teaches is not speed but *reading* — watch what it will do before deciding what to do about it. We concluded three sessions. At the end of the third the dog sat down, which for that dog is a treaty, and I sat down too, out of range, as the treaty specified, and we regarded one another with the respect of parties who have wasted none of each other's time. The silence between us on the murder night went undiscussed. Some accounts stay open.

And then the last thing, which was not fighting, and which was the reason for all the fighting.

Her ward is still on the parlor door frame. It hangs there with a hole in it the size of what walked through — the stitches lifted, not torn, a wound with straight edges. I had watched her patch that ward four hundred times: after storms, after solstices, once after an argument with the chimney that I maintain to this day the chimney started. Watching is not doing. I know that now better than any creature alive.

I got up on the frame with a mouthful of her thread from the workbox, and I mended it.

I will not pretend it was her work. My stitches sat in the old ward like a boy's writing on a master's page — fat, anxious, twice-knotted where hers would have held with a breath. It took most of a night, and one stitch I placed and unpicked eleven times because it *pulled the wrong way*; my paws wanted to run the line mirror-wise, right to left, and the ward wanted otherwise, and I remember being irritated at my own hands and thinking nothing of it. Nothing in this book costs me more.

But when it was finished the ward held. The door frame hummed again, low, the sound of a house with someone minding it, and the hole the size of what walked through was gone, and I sat on the cold hearthstone and looked at my crooked stitches in her doorway and understood that I was going to do all of it — the whole case, every thread of it — and that no one was going to stop me, including whatever had looked at me and decided I was not an interruption.

It would learn. I was exactly an interruption.

* * *

That night I walked the rounds nobody was paying for: the lamps still short-handed, the lanes that miss their light, past the drains and the dark doorways, down Needle Lane to its cold end and back. Two wisps put up their small arguments and lost them. The dog at Number Twelve stood, once, and did not bark — looked where I looked, at the fog standing at the lane's end where fog does not stand — and we held that watch together for a while, chain and cat, in the silence of colleagues.

Wisps used to be rare on this street. Used to be. The dark had noticed the missing lamps, the way water notices a low place. Somebody had to walk the line while the Lamplighters grieved.

The city I can work in is a particular kind of city. I intended to keep it.

Chapter 3

Creditors

I took the docket-scrap back to Brindle at the next dawn, because paper is her native language and mine only by adoption.

She read it the way she reads everything, head cocked, one eye at a time, and I watched her be fluent in it: the watermark, the fold-grease, the ink that had been wet in fog. “Counting-house paper,” she said. “Chandlers’ counting-house. This is the flimsy — the copy that rides with the cart. The originals live under the ledgers, second yard off Wick Row.” She flicked the scrap flat with one black claw and paused — half a second, no more, on the cart-slot seal in its corner — and if I had been less new to all this I would have priced that pause properly and asked about it. I was new. I filed it instead. Half-seconds are the whole currency of the case.

“Second yard off Wick Row,” she said again. “Mind the night shift, pet.”

* * *

Wickrow after dark is a district that has never once seen itself.

Every doorway wears a little flame — lamp above the lintel, votive in the transom, candle-boxes at the sills — and every flame is a warded bee: the Chandlers’ mark, burning in its own wax, paid up by the tenants the way other streets pay for locks. A district that sells light to people frightened of the dark, and in the whole of my

working life I have never once seen it dark. That is not comfort. That is *stock control*.

I went in over the roofs, dropped to the yards where the roofs ran out, and met the night shift.

The night shift was a hound.

Not the honest kind, that discusses territory at the end of a chain. A counting-house hound, off its chain, walked between the yards by a man with a lantern and let loose in each one in turn while he counted his keys — big-shouldered and low-voiced, and he found my scent in the second yard's woodstack and made his argument at once, in the old red language, with the door at his back and the whole yard's geometry on his side. I gave that fight everything the goose had taught me and a little of what the dog at Number Twelve had, and I will summarize it this way: I am writing this book, and that hound tells the story differently, and we are both entitled.

But it cost me the quiet. Somewhere across the yards the keys stopped counting, and the lantern came around, and boots — more than one pair — and I came out of the woodstack low and fast into the alley-mouth with the light swinging after me, and the alley-mouth was blind.

A paw hooked my scruff and hauled me sideways through a gap I had not seen, into a doorway's dead shadow, and held me there — *held me*, like luggage — while the watch went past close enough to smell the lamp-oil and the supper on them.

When the boots were two yards gone the paw let go. I turned around with every dignity I had left and found a grey tom considering me from the dark: old, big-boned under a coat that had seen weather, one eye, half of one ear, and the stillness of a creature that has spent a long time being exactly as visible as it chooses.

"You fight like a housecat," he said.

"I was one."

"Were," he agreed, and did not say sorry.

I have turned that minute over more times than any other minute I own. What I saw then was an old alley professional doing a stranger a kindness in the oldest currency the roofs deal in. What I see now — but this account has rules, and one of them is that I tell it in the order I lived it. In the order I lived it, he was the first creature since the parlor who had put a paw on me, and the paw had been *sure*,

and something in me that had been walking on three legs since the kettle went quiet put its fourth foot down.

He looked me over once, professionally, the way Cardew had looked over the room.

“Watch the paws, not the claws,” he said. “Claws are a rumor. Paws are an appointment. The dog told you where it would be four moves before it got there, and you were reading the teeth.” He tipped his head at the yard I had come out of. “Wax door, far side, under the loading beam. The counting room is behind it, and Wick’s paper is worth the reading.”

“You know what I am looking for,” I said. It was not a question, and he did not treat it as one.

“I knew your witch to look at,” he said. “Everyone did.” He was already moving, grey into grey, and at the gap in the fence he paused with the one eye half back toward me. “Bodkin,” he said — his name, given the way the old ones give it, once, take it or leave it — and was gone over the fence with no more noise than a thought.

A bodkin, she told me once, in the windowsill years, is the blunt needle. The one you use to unpick.

I took the wax door.

* * *

The counting room was warm — wax-warm, hive-warm — and lit by its own stock, and guarded, because of course it was. The Chandlers do not set dogs on their paper. They set the paper’s own keeper: a poured thing, man-high, tallow-shouldered, with a gentle unfinished face, that stood up out of the corner shadows when I crossed the threshold and placed itself between me and the ledger-shelves with the unhurried certainty of a door swinging shut.

I had learned, by then, to spend four seconds looking. I spent six. The thing was slow and its patience was perfect, and strength was not going to answer it — but it *was* a working, and a working is stitches, and stitches can be read. The threads of it ran down into the floor, into a lattice woven under the boards — an ugly, effective, journeyman weave, nothing like her hand — and a lattice is only a gate lying down. She unpicked gates in front of me four hundred

times. Watching is not doing; but I had stopped merely watching the night I mended her door.

So while the keeper leaned its warm bulk after me, always a beat behind, I went at the lattice — paw and tooth, loop by loop, in the order the weave itself suggested if you troubled to ask it — and the wrong loops fought me, and the right ones came away like a lie confessed, and on the last of them the keeper stopped mid-lean, considered its own hands with that gentle face, and poured itself politely back into the corner, off duty for the first time in years. I would almost say it looked relieved. Wax runs to sentiment. It is the bees in it.

Under the ledgers, exactly where the flimsy's watermark said they would be, the originals.

And in the originals, her name.

Vane, in a strong small impatient hand. Instruction after instruction, dated inside one single week of this spring: buy Vane's paper. All of it. The tallow debt to the renderers' yard. The two winters' rent she owed on the workroom before the good years. The chandlery account, seven years old, forgiven-in-name and never in law. *Buy it quiet, pay the premium for quiet, and call it due Lady's Day.*

Every debt my witch owed in the world, bought up in seven days, by one buyer.

I sat on the counting-house desk in the light of the enemy's own candles and made myself read it twice, because the first reading had a red wash over it and red is not a reading light. Then I folded the page — teeth and paw; there is a knack, and I have it now — and slid it into my shadow, into one of the nine pockets she sewed there, where it weighed what secrets weigh, which is nothing, and rode like a stone anyway.

Because here is what the ledger meant, and I had gone one whole roof toward home before I made myself admit it. A man who buys every debt you owe and calls them due on one date is not planning your murder. He is planning your *eviction*. Paper says what Wick wanted, and what Wick wanted was my witch out — alive, ruined, and out. You do not go to the expense of killing a woman you have spent a premium to lawfully destroy. And — this thought arrived later, on the drainpipe, and stopped me half up it — you *particularly* do not kill her if her needlework is holding shut something you profit

by. A dead seamstress mends nothing.

I needed to know what her needle had been holding for Ellery Wick. And for that I needed people who watch the Chandlers for a living and hate them fluently.

Fortunately, the city keeps a guild of exactly those.

* * *

The Lamplighters' hall burns lamps at its own door.

Think what that costs a guild that cannot spare the oil: their own light, spent outward at the dark, all night, every night, as a point of order. I came to it over the yards and stopped on the wall opposite and read the front of that building like a notice: *we are not gone. We light what we have. Come home.*

Inside, the hall was one cold room with its heart beating slow. Half the coats on the pegs hung over boots nobody had come back for — pairs of boots, toes out, waiting, under coats that kept their shapes the way the wraith on Needle Lane had kept a shape, and I understood with my whole pelt why the empty coat is the worst thing this city makes. Forty lamplighters used to walk Hollowmere. What was left of the guild fit in that one room, around one lamp, with room to spare.

They knew me the moment I came in — *the witch's cat* went around the room in the way words go around a room full of people not saying them — and the room braced. A grieving hall, and a cat in it, wanting something. I know what I am; I know what my wanting costs rooms like that.

The one to convince was obvious. Torn ear; chalk on her paws — hands; I keep the ledger in my own tongue — a shift-boss's way of standing, facing the door, near the lamp, where the next bad news would have to go through her first. Merrow.

I did not lay Wick's page down. Paper first is an auditor's manners. Instead I did the thing I had been carrying up through my chest since the doorway, which had the advantage of being true: I looked at the coats over the boots, and I asked — in the plain way, whiskers down, no performance — after their missing.

The room stopped bracing.

“Not dead,” Merrow said. Flat, fast, a door long since slammed on that word. “The Court said not dead. Our filings came back *marked*: no appointments under those names. So they are SOMEWHERE—” and here her voice did the thing that grief does when it has been on shift too long, which is nothing at all, “— and this hall lights lamps until they walk back in.”

She looked at me a long moment, chalk-handed, torn-eared, and something about a cat asking after the missing instead of the murder seemed to settle a question I had not known I was sitting.

“Walk my round with me, cat,” she said. “Rounds first. Paper after.” So she had seen the page’s corner in my shadow after all. You do not make shift-boss by missing things.

* * *

Her round was forty-one lamps, and something was walking it ahead of us.

We both saw it by the fifth: lamps she had lit at the round’s head, dark again behind us — not blown, not failed; *drunk*, wicks wet and whole, the little warded bees drained to grease. And the order of the darkening was her order, her exact route, the sequence her guild has walked so long it has worn a groove in the evening. At the fifteenth lamp we doubled back quiet and caught them at it: a pair of wisps, fat as lamp-oil themselves, working her lamps *in sequence*, one keeping watch while the other drank.

Wisps do not do that. Let me put it as plainly as I can, because it is the hinge of everything that follows: a wisp is appetite in a bottle. Appetite does not read route-maps. Appetite goes to the nearest, the brightest, the easiest — it does not skip a bright lamp to keep a *schedule*. These two had been taught. Something had walked this round with them enough nights to teach appetite a route, the way you teach a dog a beat, and had chosen, of all the rounds in the city, the round that stitches Wickrow’s dark shut.

Merrow took the left one and I took the right, and a shift-boss of the Lamplighters, it turns out, swings a ladder like a guildhall falling, and the fight was short and the lane the brighter for it. She relit her lamps in order — *her* order — to the round’s end, and at the

hall door she chalked a fresh tally on the wood, one stroke among hundreds, and I understood that the strokes were rounds completed since the night of the missing, and that the tally was itself a lamp of a kind.

“You came about the night,” she said. “Ask, then. I answer what is asked. No more.”

That is a lamplighter’s honesty and I respect it and it is a doorway exactly the width of your own wits. I sat, and thought, and asked — not *who killed her*, which she could not know, nor *what happened to your missing*, which she would have answered with the Court’s cruel paperwork and nothing more — but this: “What work did Elspeth Vane do in Wickrow that nobody paid for?”

Marrow looked at me the way you look at a colleague who has just found the fault you had walked past. Then she took down the shift-book from behind the meeting-board, and opened it to a page her thumb knew, and laid the page where I could read it.

“That is Wick’s hand,” she said, tapping the requisition pasted at the head. “And that is the night nobody signed.”

The tally ran down two facing pages, and it said this: for two years, at the turn of every season and after every hard blow off the Mere, ward-shifts at the *Wickhouse* — the guild’s great warehouse on the Mere-edge — logged, walked, witnessed, and paid to *nobody*. The escort-lamplighter’s fee in the book, every time; the stitcher’s fee, blank, every time. She sewed a rich man’s warehouse shut, season upon season, for free. Nobody sews free. She least of anyone — I have watched her price a churn-blessing to the ha’penny and chase the ha’penny.

Unless the sewing was not for the rich man at all. Unless what her needle held shut in that warehouse was something she would have paid to keep held, and the rich man merely owned the building it lived behind, and knew what he had, and let a witch ruin her evenings and her ledgers on it for two years, gratis, while he bought up her debts with the money her work was saving him.

I did not say any of this at the hall. It was not yet mine to say. But Marrow watched me reading, and read me reading, and when I looked up her face had the grim satisfaction of a woman whose grievance has finally found a colleague.

One more thing happened in that hall, and I set it down because

the city should know it. Behind the meeting-board their own ward hung torn — the hall's hem, the guild's own guard-stitching, ripped the night of the missing and left that way, because the one who always mended it was one of the coats. They had been living inside a torn ward for a season sooner than let anyone else touch her seam. Merrow saw me looking. The whole room saw Merrow seeing.

Cats inspect seams. It is the ancient arrangement; nobody has ever said it aloud, and nobody needed to then. I got up on the meeting-board, and I mended their ward in front of everybody — better than the parlor door; I had been practicing on grief for weeks by then — and when it was done the hall hummed faintly, the sound of a room with someone minding it, and one of the four remaining lamplighters put his face in his hands, and everyone else looked at the lamp.

Merrow walked me to the door. At the threshold, in front of her whole guild, she tied a lamplighter's knot into the thread at my chest — rough work, honest, tight — where the entire Weft could read it.

"The hall owes the cat," she said, for the room.

And then, bending close, for me alone, in the voice she keeps for the end of bad shifts:

"Wisps do not learn a route. Somebody taught them the taste. Find the teacher."

Chapter 4

The City Talks

Find the teacher, she said. But a teacher is found through pupils, and the night's pupils were scattered across three guilds and two species, so I went and asked everyone in the city who cannot keep a secret, starting with the ones who keep them best.

The Ratsmeet convenes under the fish market in the hour the ice melts. Not poetry: scheduling. When the fishmongers' ice runs down through the gratings, the under-market turns briefly uninhabitable to anything that minds wet feet, and rats do not, and one sufficiently motivated cat did not. The rat-kingdoms are a nation under the floor — organized, literate, unionized — and nothing moves through the Shambles at night that a rat does not book.

There is a protocol for a cat attending, and I had it from Mirri the ratcatcher's daughter: do not eat anybody; do not say "trap"; do not say "terrier"; do not be a cat about it; and do not argue with the doorman, who is a goose. This one considered my references at the culvert-mouth, hissed once on principle, and let me through with the air of one who wanted it understood that admission and approval were separate line items.

The Grey Boss holds court on a throne of corks.

He is old the way paper is old: grey to the point of transparency, whiskers gone wispy, eyes like wet ink. "I remember the ninth bell," he said, before I had finished sitting. "You will hear it said no one does. I am no one, then." The court laughed the way courts laugh. He watched me not laugh.

I put my question with the manners Mirri had drilled — to the

Meet, not the Boss — and asked about the murder night on Needle Lane.

“The witch’s cat,” said the Grey Boss. “We had a lively night. Everyone had a lively night.”

A rat’s silence is a price list. So is a rat’s phrasing. *A lively night* — on a lane his own bookings would show empty. Unless the liveliness was the emptiness itself: a whole nation under the floor, booking nothing, all night, on a street that had never needed booking — and being paid, or frightened, or *favoured* into finding that unremarkable.

“You cannot clear out of an empty street,” I said, slowly, watching him. “But you can be cleared out of one that is about to stop being empty.”

The old rat’s ears made a small movement his court could not see. “The cat can count,” he said, dry as his corks. Then he gave me my change: “A cart,” he said. “No chandler on it — we know the chandlers’ boys, every one, and this driver we did not know and have not seen since. And behind the cart, in no hurry, a gentleman. Going nowhere in particular, the whole way down the lane.”

“What sort of gentleman?”

“The sort you don’t book,” said the Grey Boss, and the whole Ratsmeet went quiet, and the audience was over, and the goose saw me out with one satisfied hiss.

By morning, I knew, the Chandlers would hear a cat had been asking. Good. Nervous men check their locks, and checking your locks tells the whole street which doors matter to you.

* * *

The pigeons took longer, because the pigeons were having an election.

The Pigeon Post is Hollowmere’s gossip made systematic: whoever leads the Post decides what the city overhears. They elect a Postmaster by hat — the whole electorate perches at once on the brim of its candidate’s chosen hat, and the hat that bows lowest wins. I am told the founders considered this incorruptible. It had not occurred to them that somebody might simply feed the electorate.

A slick young cock-pigeon called Toby was winning on unlimited seed.

It was my problem because of the one fact this whole account keeps circling: the night my witch died, every pigeon in the city went quiet at once. Not frightened quiet, which is loud the moment the fright passes. *Bought* quiet. And now here was an election swimming in mystery seed, and I do not believe in prosperous coincidences.

I followed the seed backward: nights on the roofline, upwind, unhurried, walking the supply line back hop by hop — ledge, gutter, chute — without once being seen following. The trail ended above Needle Lane, at a grain-chute swept a little too neatly, and there the arithmetic announced itself: good seed, bought in bulk, and hauled *up*. Nobody hauls seed up. Seed falls; that is the entire economic principle of being a pigeon. This seed had been carried to the rooftops and scattered from above, wide as weather, by somebody with *hands*.

I took what I had to the Perch — full assembly, hats and all — and put it before the old Postmaster, because some testimony only works in public. I laid it out in order, the way she taught me: the seed, the chute, the hauling-up, the particular night the whole Post had spent with its beaks full. And I watched an old bird's pride fight an old bird's honesty, feather by feather, and honesty win by a neck.

"We voted with our beaks full," he said, at last, to the assembly, "and we called the quiet weather."

From a Postmaster, before the whole Perch, that is a confession with plumage. The roosts went up in the kind of noise they had failed to make on the night that mattered. Toby attempted a point of order and was sat on by his own electors, which is the only pigeon institution I have ever admired without reservation. Elections were suspended pending fresh hats and a seed audit.

But mark what the confession actually said, because it is the chapter's whole cargo: the seed came *before* the night. Days before. Laid in like stores against a winter. The murder was not an act of passion that happened to find the city conveniently deaf; the murder had a *quartermaster* — someone who provisioned the silence in advance, in bulk, by hand, the way a clerk provisions a shipment. I went home over the roofs with that word sitting in my chest like swallowed lead, and under her old window a lamplighter was relighting Needle Lane, and the first pigeon in a month settled onto the ledge above the dark glass and said something rude about me to the whole street.

The city was talking again. I had never in my life been so glad to be insulted.

* * *

Then the city, having resumed talking, talked about me, and I was summoned to court.

Not the Hollow Court. The other one. The Court of Whiskers convenes on the ropewalk roof at the wrong hour on purpose — a cat who will not lose sleep for the law is a cat whose opinion the law can spare — and I arrived on the summons of three yowls and a dead moth left on my sill, which is how our bar serves papers. The docket that night was a kitten.

Tansy: small, orange, absurd, with the build of a mitten and the conviction of a siege engine. Her case, as the seniors laid it out from their chimney-stacks, was this: to save her three brothers when the spring flood took their crate down the canal, she had sold her purr to the Quiet Gentleman for the favor that fished them out.

The contract was legal. That was the scandal of it. No theft, no trick: consideration given — three lives; consideration received — one purr, surrendered in escrow. But a kitten without a purr cannot be comforted and cannot comfort, which is the entire profession of a kitten, and the Court of Whiskers wanted the precedent *killed* — every tail on that roof went still while the name was said — before the Gentleman opened a *market* in such things.

The kitten slept in the lee of a chimney through her own hearing. Midway through the arguments she woke, located me — I do not know how; we had never met — marched across the assembled jurisprudence of the rooftops, sat down against my flank, and told the Court: “This is my counsel. He is the best one.”

I had issued no such appointment. The Court minuted it anyway. I am given to understand the minute stands to this day, and that it is the only thing in the archives of the Court of Whiskers with a smile in the pawwriting.

What could I do? I did the job. The old ones gave me the one piece of law that matters — *he never signs anything that can be settled; read it before you touch it* — and I went down to the Shambles

strongroom where his paper lodges. No guards; his paper guards itself, and that should tell you most of what the later chapters will cost. On a shelf in that dry dark, her purr: a small knot of thread in escrow, purring faintly to itself, which is the loneliest sound I have heard in a city that contains the Hollow Court.

And the knot had grown a loop nobody tied.

I read it three times in the Weft-light, as the Court had charged me. The contract was flawless — his contracts always are; flawlessness is his signature — but a purr is not inert goods. A purr *accrues*. Warmth begets warmth even on a shelf, and a season's interest had knotted itself a loop that appeared in no schedule, because his paper is exact and exactness cuts both ways: what is not conveyed is not conveyed. The interest was nobody's, and an unclaimed loop may be unpicked by any finder, and a knot grown into another knot comes undone *with* it, if the unpicking is clean. Three nights, the last until nearly dawn, loop by loop, her small stubborn purr humming against my paws like a trapped bee getting hopeful — and it came loose all at once, like a cork, and went home at volume.

I am told — I was there; “I am told” is cowardice; I *saw* — that Tansy, three streets away on the hearthrug where she had installed herself without leave two days earlier, woke mid-purr, purred so hard she fell off the rug, and went back to sleep still running.

On the empty shelf where the escrow had sat: a calling card. Blank, both faces, smelling faintly of fog. It had not been there when I started.

I carried it home in a shadow-pocket — it weighed what secrets weigh — and pinned it to the board beside the candle stub and the docket and the shroud thread, and sat on the mantel a long time looking at the only blank exhibit in my case, which said, more clearly than print: *noted*. — *G*.

Tansy stayed. I explained to her that I live alone. “Yes,” she said. “We live alone.” She moved the remainder of her personal effects — one chewed bootlace — behind the coal scuttle. She sleeps on my paws, which obstructs the paws, and purrs like a small wrong engine, and somewhere in the Gentleman's strongroom a page of his ledger is one line lighter, and I have been advised by the Court of Whiskers to consider what that will someday cost me, and I have considered it, and I find I would pay it again.

* * *

One more thing belongs here, because not everything the city said, once it was talking again, was about murder.

The Fish-Giver missed two dawns.

For eleven years that man has set out scraps behind his stall at first light for half the strays of Thimblefield — rain, frost, fish-glut or fish-famine — and stood in his doorway saying good morning to animals who officially are not there. He has never learned my name; every cat is “puss,” with the same democratic courtesy he shows the magistrates who buy his herring. Two dawns, no scraps, and the half of Thimblefield that eats behind his stall assembled on his roof-ridge like a jury, and I went down, because cats do not worry — cats *investigate*.

The trouble was on his door, in paper: rent behind, lease called, seven days — through a bank that banks for the Chandlers. Nobody was going to knife the Fish-Giver in his parlor; they were going to *file* him out of it. All season I had been learning what this city does with knives; here was its ink, and it smelled of a counting room in Wickrow. No monsters, no wraiths, no wisps: a human-sized catastrophe, and it wanted cat-sized assets. He had three, and did not know he had any.

The first was down his own drainpipe: his grandmother’s brooch, lost nine years ago and mourned to every customer since — a story I had dozed through from his roof forty times. No hand fits that pipe. A paw does. One wet shoulder and a bent whisker later, the brooch lay on his step at midnight, and at dawn he sat down on his own threshold with it and cried like a well-fed child. Fenced honest at Brindle’s rates, its gleam was worth precisely a quarter-day of rent, which is not what it was worth to him — and that is the point of gleam, and the reason the Exchange will outlast the banks.

The second asset was the pigeon-net, newly loquacious and feeling it owed me: the landlord’s man, the roosts reported within the hour, takes his evenings loudly at the Bent Anchor, and has a sister, and the sister is a magistrate.

The third was that the magistrate keeps a cat, who owed me a favor of long standing, and the favor was called and paid off the page, cat fashion: silently, completely, neither government consulted. Certain

paperwork was reviewed; a lease's calling was found procedurally defective; and a bank which banks for the Chandlers chose, on reflection, not to have the defect examined in open court.

Dawn, three days later. The shutter went up. The scraps went down. The jury on the roof-ridge dissolved into a congregation, and the Fish-Giver stood in the middle of it grinning at nothing, wearing his grandmother on his coat, saying good morning to animals who officially are not there.

He never learned any of it. That is the point. That is the whole point. Somewhere my witch was — wherever the tide files its cases — knowing perfectly well what I had been doing all week, saying *not on the table, Ash*, and meaning what she always meant.

Chapter 5

The Ward That Failed

The Wickhouse squats on the Mere-edge, fat as a tick, and every stone of it is warded in her stitch.

I had known the building my whole life the way you know a rich man's back: something large that faces away from you. Now I stood on the sea-wall at dusk with Merrow's shift-book tally in my memory and Wick's ledger-page in my shadow, and I read the place with my new eyes, and what I read stopped my breath. Her seam ran the whole water wall — foundation to chimneys, stitch upon stitch upon year upon year of stitches, the biggest single working I had ever seen outside the one I had not yet seen. Two years of unpaid ward-shifts, the tally said. The tally was modest. That wall held a *decade* of her evenings, and I could name the seasons of it: that hard winter; that flood-spring; that autumn she came home smelling of pond-water and would not say why and sat closer to the fire than the fire required.

Bodkin was on the sea-wall.

I had not seen him arrive, which by then I understood to be the only way he arrived. He sat looking at the water — not the warehouse; the water — with his one eye half shut, an old grey stone among the granite ones.

"Keep your feet dry and your business short," he said, without preamble, as I came up. "And go in by the wax door, not the water door."

"You know the building."

"Everyone on this side of the wall knows the building." He looked

at it then, briefly, the way you glance at a debt. “Nothing good ever came off that water. You are going in anyway.”

“I am.”

“Then that is the geometry of it,” he said, and settled deeper into his coat, and stayed exactly where he was, on the stone. “I don’t go in there.”

I have promised to tell this in the order I lived it, and in the order I lived it, that was an old cat’s sensible fear of a bad building, and it made me trust him more, not less. An adviser who shares your risks is a comrade; an adviser who names the risks he will not share is honest. I put him down in the ledger as honest. I want the reader to see me do it — see me write *honest*, in my own careful hand, about the sentence *I don’t go in there* — because this book is a case file, and a case file must show its errors, and that entry is not an error. Every word he said to me on that wall was true. It took me the rest of my lives to learn what the truth is for.

* * *

Getting to the wax door is the Mereside’s own toll.

The fog on those terraces has residents. I paid my way across — patience at the curbs, shadow in the long stretches, and at the last crossing, where the cold came up through my pads like a hand closing, the pale strength again, spent freely — and even so I did not arrive unmet. Between me and the door handle, dry-footed on a street glazed with wet, stood one of the Drowned.

I had heard of them all my life and seen them never: the Mere’s patient people. It did not lunge and it did not stalk. It *arrived* — that is the whole motion they own; they are always arriving, the way the tide is always arriving, and the horror of it is precisely that there is no hurry in it anywhere. It regarded me with the mild interest of deep water, and it stood where it stood because something under the lake preferred that door unopened, and I understood for the first time, in my pelt and not merely in my ledger, that my case had two sides, and that one side was a murder, and the other side was *old*, and wet, and did not have habits so much as tides.

What does a cat do against the patience of water? What she taught me. You do not outwait the tide; you use its schedule. The

Drowned arrive; therefore they are never quite *here*. I spent the red all at once — not at the thing, past it, one committed burst through the gap its arriving had not yet closed — and I was through the wax door with the fog's fingers still turning where my tail had been.

Inside: wax to the rafters.

White hills of it, tallow-bergs and beeswax cliffs, aisle upon aisle in the gloom, a hundred winters of light not yet sold. The merchant smell lay over everything, honey and render and coin. And under the merchant smell, the way a signature lies under a seal, the other smell. Pond-bottom. Old rope. Patience.

The wax was not stock. The wax was *feed*.

I walked those aisles the better part of an hour, and the sums assembled themselves around me like the case-board come to life. The Chandlers' fortune says the city buys its light out of fear of the dark. But here was the reserve, the deep cellar of the trade, stacked against a wall the Mere touches — and along that wall, her seam, and against her seam, on the waterside, something that fed. The guild's ledgers would call it spoilage: so many hundredweight of stock written off each quarter, damp-lost, rat-lost — the rats, who book everything, would laugh their transparent grey laughter at that line. The wax went to the wall and the wall's tenant took it, and her stitching held the tenant to its side of the bargain, and Ellery Wick's entire empire stood on a seam he got for free from a witch who could not afford to let it fail.

Her ward did not fail. I am ahead of myself. But so was she; so was everyone; the whole city was ahead of itself and did not know it.

Halfway down the water wall I found the place where the seam was wrong, and before I tell you what I found I must tell you where I went, because in the middle of that cold warehouse, with my nose an inch from her stitching, I fell into a Remembered Day, and it was the first one, and I did not choose it.

They come from sleeping in dangerous places — some economy of the pale strength, spending itself as memory when the body will not spend it as anything else. I had not slept in days. I stood at the wall with her thread-scent in my head, and between one breath and the next it was years ago, and warm, and her table was under me instead of stone.

The same chart. That is what undid me: the chart of this same

water wall, half-sewn, spread across her table in lamplight — and a much smaller cat deployed on top of it as a paperweight, asleep, entirely certain of the world. Her voice above me, amused, talking to her needle the way she did when the work was long:

“That winter I tried eight strays. Every one declined the interview. Wise animals. The ninth fell asleep on my work—” the needle going down, through, drawn, the little tug, a word ending, “—and I took it for a signature.”

I came back to the cold with my paws on the actual wall, on the actual stitches the dream had shown me half-sewn, and I stood there while the warehouse dark leaned in, doing the sum I had been refusing all season. Eight strays declined. The ninth signed. She kept count of strays the way she kept count of nothing else in her cheerful shambles of a house, and Cardew’s voice on the quay: *you were her ninth, you know. She would never say what she meant by keeping count.*

Nine of us. There were nine of something else, too, and the Clerk had not filed one since he sat at a much smaller desk. I wrote the two nines side by side in the ledger of my chest and drew no line between them yet. But I felt the line wanting to be drawn, the way you feel weather.

* * *

Now the seam.

At the near end, man-height and below, her work was *wrong*, and the wrongness was of a kind I had no word for and have had to build one. Not torn — tearing leaves violence in the thread, and there was none. Not burned, not rotted, not the Mere’s slow patient chewing, which I could see and recognize further down, held off by every stitch. *Undone*. Each stitch lifted out clean and whole, the way she herself lifted stitches when a hem displeased her — her exact movement, her exact order, the little releasing twist at the top of each — but run *backward*. Unsewn in the precise reverse of the sewing, as if time had been persuaded to reread a page from the bottom.

I did the only thing that would let me be sure. I re-sewed a hand’s length of it, her pattern, my own paws — and to re-sew what was

unsewn I had to follow the unsewing, stitch into the ghost of each lifted stitch, and my paws, following, *ran the line mirror-wise*. Right to left. The way my paws had wanted to run her door-ward, when I stood on the frame irritated at my own hands and thinking nothing of it.

Whoever unpicked this wall did it in her own stitch, mirrored, faster than any needle honestly goes. Perfect technique. And Elspeth Vane taught exactly nobody — the Circuit begged her for apprentices for thirty years and she turned away every one; ask Cardew; everyone asked Cardew.

The lifted thread told me the second finding of the wall. It lay where the unpicking had dropped it, loose coils along the foot of the stone, and when I took it up to work with it there was nothing in it. Dead slack. A stitch of hers, standing, holds what she paid into it — an evening banked in every hand's length; that is the whole trade of warding. These coils were spent thread, empty the full length of them, nothing of what was paid in coming back out at the lifted end. Whoever ran her seam backward had unlocked the wall and recovered not one evening of the decade. Undone is not refunded.

I took the hand's length of her thread away with me — evidence: hers, then mine — and I went out by the wax door with the warehouse dark at my back, and Bodkin was gone from the sea-wall.

A case wants stating. She talked to her needle when the work was long, and I had taken it for company; it was method. A finding kept in the chest is a finding you can still argue with. So I stated mine aloud, to the empty wall, in the flat voice you keep for entering evidence, there being nobody on the stone to hear it: "The slack comes off dead. Coils of spent thread, nothing left in them. What was paid into the stitching does not come back out at the unpicking."

And the fog over the stone held the shape of a sitting cat for one second longer than fog holds anything, and in the order I lived it, that was only the fog.

On the wall where he had sat, the sum of the chapter sat instead, and it said: the wax feeds a thing the guild will not name. Her ward holds the thing. She held the ward unpaid, for years, in secret. And the man who profits by all of it *bought her debts and called them due*.

Coincidence, she used to say, is what mice call carelessness.

It was time to meet Ellery Wick.

* * *

The invitation, when it came, was a candle.

That is how the Chandlers grant audience: a beeswax taper arrives, trimmed by the guild's own chandler to burn exactly one hour, stamped with the bee at the base. You light it and start walking, and if it dies before you reach the Guildhall, so does the appointment. It is a rich man's way of pricing your eagerness, and it is also — I admit it with the reluctance owed to an enemy's craft — rather beautiful.

They had sized the taper for a man's stride. I carried it lit through the evening streets in my teeth.

The image deserved a dignity it did not receive: a black cat crossing three districts at speed with a live flame borne before him like a comet with dignity problems, fog curling off the wick-heat, wax dripping — I will say it — onto the whiskers, which took a week to feel right again. Children pointed. A watchman blessed himself.

I arrived with a quarter-inch to spare.

The Guildhall of the Chandlers is a chapel to the bee. Ten thousand lit votives line its hall, tier upon tier, and the heat stands in the room like a body — you walk into it as into surf. Above, the great combs of the guild's own hives mutter behind bronze grilles. And between me and the stair, the keeper of the hall unfolded from beside the votive-tiers: a tower of poured wax with a gentle face — cousin to my counting-room acquaintance, but built to another scale entirely, a cathedral of a creature, warm as the room and patient as the room, with hands like dripping bells.

"The Guildmaster will see you presently," it said, in a voice like a wick drowning, and *presently*, in the grammar of such keepers, meant: *when you have shown the hall what you are*.

I will not make the fight longer in the telling than it was in the doing; it shames a warm room to be fought in. The keeper was slow, and enormous, and lit — and that was the reading of it, in four seconds of looking: a thing of wax serves the flame it carries, and ten thousand flames in tiers make a weather of rising air, and a cat who cannot out-muscle a cathedral can out-draft one. I led its gentle

bulk on a tour of its own votive-tiers, close and fast, and the wind of its turning did what I could never do: bowed a hundred flames toward its own body, softened it at the shoulders, at the knees — until it stopped, mid-reach, considered the puddling of its own wrists with that unfinished face, and withdrew with immense courtesy to its alcove, conceding the stair.

She would have laughed until she needed the chair. I climbed the stair and was seen presently.

* * *

Ellery Wick is a small man behind a desk built to make everything else in the room smaller, and he was already talking when the door finished opening.

“The ward-cat! The seam-mender — the hall talks, the whole row talks, sit — no, not there, the good chair. The good chair, I insist.” Warm, voluble, quick-eyed, in guild black with beeswax-colored facings; warm the way his hall is warm, which is to say: *by the burning of something*. I took the good chair. It is a mistake to refuse a frightened man’s hospitality; it tells him you have already decided.

And he was frightened. Under the patter, under the desk and the facings, Ellery Wick was a man who had been doing sums at night, and I had come to check his working.

I laid the whole case on his desk, item by item, in the order a cat lays out prey. The ledger page in his own hand: buy Vane’s paper, all of it, due Lady’s Day. Merrow’s tally: two years of ward-shifts at his warehouse, paid to nobody. The hand’s length of her thread from his own water wall, unpicked in her mirrored stitch. The docket-scrap from the gutter of Needle Lane, consignee scratched out. And I watched him meet each exhibit, and here is my testimony, for what a cat’s reading of a man is worth in whatever court finally hears all this: at the ledger he flinched like a man touched on a bruise he knew he had. At the thread he went *blank* — honest, ignorant blank, the blank of a man shown a wound in a language he cannot read.

Then he did the thing I had not priced. He got up, opened his own strong-cabinet, and laid his books on the desk beside my exhibits.

All of them. True books — I know true books now; I have been schooled by rats and magpies, the finest forensic faculty in the city — and the true books said what the stolen page had said, and worse, and he narrated his own disgrace item by item in a voice that got steadier as it got more damning, because Ellery Wick is a coward about everything except arithmetic.

“I wanted her evicted,” he said. “I wanted her *out*, cat. Out of the district, out of the trade, out of — reach. Her lease, her debts, her standing — I bought the lot, and I timed the calling for Lady’s Day because the Circuit meets at Lady’s Day and the humiliation would be public and she would have to *go*.” He looked at the thread lying on his blotter, and his hands stopped. “You do not kill the one needle holding your roof shut. You do not kill the needle. Whatever you have decided I am — and I can read a cat’s face better than my clerks think — follow the sum. Alive and ruined, she re-wards my wall from whatever gutter I chase her to. She was proud like that. She’d have done it to spite me. Dead—” and his voice went, at last, where his sums had already gone, “—dead, my wall is a larder with the pantry door coming open, and I am the man who fed the thing behind it for thirty years. So ask me your question. I have been asking it myself since the bells rang eight that night and I sat here *hoping* it was me she’d ruined herself for. Who else knew the ward was hers?”

I looked at him a long time. Then I put my last question in front of him, flat as a docket: *a cart went down Needle Lane that night. Your cart-slot. Who signed it out?*

And Ellery Wick, guildmaster, monopolist, terror of leaseholds, went and fetched the counterfoil like an errand boy, and laid it down, and it was worse than anything in his books.

The cart-slot had been signed out against *favor-paper*. Not coin, not credit: a favor the Chandlers’ Guild itself owed — owed for years, incurred by his own father’s generation, the sort of debt that sits in a strongroom and is never, ever called — called in that week, blind, no name given, no name *asked*, the guild’s own seal pressed beside a signature line that held no signature at all. Just a small, neat knot, drawn in ink. A knot of thread, on paper.

“Everything in this city comes through the usual quiet channels,” Wick said, very quietly, for a man built of noise. “You do not ask.

The not-asking is what the quiet *costs*. I have paid it my whole life. I never once asked what I was buying.” He pushed the counterfoil across the desk to me with one finger. “Take it. Ruin me with it if you like. I find I would rather be ruined than be next.”

* * *

I could have squeezed him. The choice existed, and choices are the spine of any honest account: a guildmaster’s knot tied into my thread where the whole Weft could see it would have opened every warded door in Wickrow to me for a year. He watched me decide what to do with him — which was, of all the fear in that room, the most honest fear in it.

I exposed him.

By eight bells the next evening the Lamplighters had his books, and by nine the criers did. The terror margin — the fat quarter of every candle’s price that was fear and not wax — died on the counting-room floor within the week. Merrow read the ward-shift page aloud from the hall steps, twice, the second time slower, to a street that got very quiet, and a district that had bought its light out of fright for a generation learned exactly what its fright had been worth, and to whom. Wick kept his desk. Barely. The guild’s own arithmetic saved him: he was the only man in the building who understood the water wall’s true accounts, and now every soul in Wickrow knew there *were* true accounts, and that the cat had them. He needs me now — the cat who ruined him — which she would have called the correct way round for a rich man to need anybody.

And so ended, formally, the first file of the case. Ellery Wick: guilty — of debts bought quiet, of a witch’s decade taken free, of feeding a nameless thing on the Mere-side of his wall and pricing the city’s fear of it — and innocent, provably, structurally innocent, of the murder of Elspeth Vane. You do not evict a woman you have had killed. I crossed him off, and I confess the crossing-off cost me: a suspect crossed off is a door closed, and the room behind the remaining doors gets darker by exactly that much light.

Home, then. The board on the chimney breast received the last pin of the season: the counterfoil, with its inked knot in the signature

line, and from it a length of grey wool I ran with my own paws — past the candle stub, past the docket, past the blank calling card that smelled of fog — off the board's edge entirely, toward the window, toward the south of the city, where the favor-paper of every guild drains when it is called, where the carts change hands and the quiet channels run to ground.

Gravamen. The undertakers' district; the Court-adjacent shadow-market where debts go to be owned.

The quiet channels had an address now. Tansy slept on my paws while I sat up over the board, and the one uncut strand of her stirred in the draft under the window, and for the first time since the kettle I felt the case *move* — the whole weight of it, slow, like a barge coming off the mud.

Somebody in Gravamen had spent a knot of thread to put a cart on Needle Lane. In the morning, I went to meet the sort of gentleman you don't book.

Part II

The Quiet Roosts

Chapter 6

The Quiet Gentleman

Gravamen is where the city keeps everything it would rather not look at, which is why it is the best-looking district in Hollowmere.

The undertakers have money, and taste, and no neighbors who complain. Black brick, white trim, brass fittings with no fingerprints on them. The Horological Society keeps its tower there, running four minutes slow. The Undertakers' Circle keeps its quiet yards. And below it all, in a sense that is not quite geography, Gravamen is Court-adjacent: the Hollow Court's day-side face, the place where the paperwork of endings is drafted before it is filed in the building under everything. Debts drain to Gravamen the way water drains to the Mere. It is the city's low place for owing.

I did not arrive well. The arrangement I have with the reader is total honesty, and what happened on the way matters to the file.

The rag-wraiths took me at the boundary of the district, where the fog off the canals meets the crematory warmth and makes a weather with opinions. Three of them — three; I had never heard of two together, and here were three working as a *set*, a wardrobe of the missing: a drover's coat, a housemaid's apron still tied at the waist of nobody, and a child's sunday jacket that I will not describe further because some inventory belongs to no file. The seam of the city was loosening — Cardew had said it, Merrow's lamps said it, and here it was said again in worsted and calico: more missing, more empty clothes walking, the Hush — the old binding that keeps the city's two sides politely strangers — fraying from the middle outward.

I fought well. Not vanity; calibration: I fought better than the

cat who died in the parlor by an order of magnitude, and it was not enough, because three is not one, and the child's jacket fought *wrong* — small and quick and heedless, the way its owner must have been — and while I answered it the drover's coat came down on me like weather off a hill.

The cold went. Then the noise. Then the part of me that was worried about the noise.

The corridor. The filing. The desk. The Clerk was already shaking his head.

"You are not on the docket." He held the sheet up, translucent fingers, that winter-sounding pen laid down beside it. "No appointment, no death. We do not process walk-ins."

There was one chair in front of the desk. I sat in it. There had been three of them, I said. The child's jacket alone—

"A defeat off the docket spends no life," said the Clerk. "You will be sent back up, minus a filing fee and whatever your satchel held. A *true* death is announced. You will know the appointments when you keep them."

He took the fee — a measured pinch of my banked shine. Then he drew my thread out across the desk for the filing. Partway along it he stopped. There was a knot in the thread, small and grey, close-worked. He was still a moment too long. Then he took up the pen, wrote two words in the margin of my file, and laid it down again. I read the words upside down: CLERICAL ERROR.

He brought the stamp down. In all that quiet it was very loud.

The stamp said REFUSED. It was still a paw print.

"The gutter two streets east of where you fell drains poorly," he said, as I left, without looking up. "If you are quick, the satchel will still be there. Your file is becoming irregular."

The stairs up are longer than the fall down. They are no shorter for the practice.

* * *

I retrieved the satchel — the Clerk's drainage intelligence was, like everything at that desk, exact — and I sat on a Gravamen roof in the last of the night, putting my coat and my nerve back in order, and that is when I saw the third thread.

Understand what the sky of this city looks like to me by now. Threads everywhere, always: the day-side's ten thousand small tethers, and over them the great slow cables of the guilds, and here and there, rare as comets, a *familiar-thread* — the deep silver line that runs between a witch and her bound creature, the kind I wore for fifteen years, the kind that hangs cut at my chest with one strand left. You cannot mistake one for anything else. It has a note in it. It hums with the two lives it joins, and the hum is a chord.

Over Gravamen, strung high between the Horologists' slow tower and the fog, ran a familiar-thread humming a chord of one.

Not mine. Mine hangs at my own chest; I know its weight the way you know your own heartbeat. Not hers. Hers I would know under floodwater, and hers ended, cut clean, over the black glass of the Mere. A third: old silver gone the grey of long weather, taut, tended, *alive* — and with no witch on the end of it. I sat very still on that roof and followed it with my eyes as far as eyes would go: south and west, out over the terraces, toward the water. A familiar-thread with one voice in the chord. A bound creature whose witch does not answer, and whose thread has not been cut.

The ledger in my chest opened to the page with the two nines on it, and I did not write the line between them, and my not-writing it had begun to feel like holding a door shut with my back.

There was a knot in the thread's far slack, I thought — too far to be sure, a small close-worked interruption in the line, old-fashioned — and while I stared at it, dawn came up over Gravamen, and somewhere below me a door I had not noticed opened, and stayed open, in the manner of a door that is *for* you.

I had come to find the Quiet Gentleman. I should have known better than to think finding him was a thing I would do, rather than a thing that would be done to me.

* * *

His office is not hidden. That is the first thing to report about it: no cellar, no password, no crooked stair. A tall black-brick house on Gravamen's best square, brass plate polished blank — blank, like the card — door ajar at the exact angle of expectation. Inside, a hall

smelling of fog and beeswax — *beeswax*; item — and a long room of shelves that I mistook, for one honest heartbeat, for the Hollow Court's, because they were filled floor to ceiling with folders tied in ribbon.

Not grey ribbon. Every color. Every color a promise is made in.

He was at the window, looking out at the square, and I want to do for the reader what nobody managed to do for me, which is describe him. I cannot. Neither can anyone else; I have since asked rats, magpies, gargoyles, and a ghost. He is a gentleman, and he is quiet. There is a coat, of good cloth; there are gloves. Above the collar the eye slides, politely, the way it slides off other people's grief. No one remembers meeting him for the first time, and I — this is the part I can least explain — I cannot remember whether that morning *was* my first time. The room was strange to me and my paws knew the floor.

"The witch's cat," he said. His voice is the sound a signature would make. "No. My error. The Needle's *heir*." He turned from the window. "You have been spending well: a magpie's regard, a lamplighter's knot, an old mother's debt, a guildmaster ruined into gratitude. And one purr, recovered against my house's paper." Nothing in his tone accused. Accusation is settlement's first cousin, and settlement is the one thing that starves him. "You are collecting, little rival. It is well done. I say so professionally."

"I have questions."

"You have *payment*," he corrected, gently, and gestured, and I understood the gesture was the room's whole law. On a reading-table by the window lay a single folder, untied, and beside it, in a dish, exactly the space where a favor-knot would sit.

What I did next I set down in the way my witch would pass on review, so: I looked first. Four seconds and more. The folder was the counterfoil's twin — his own file of the transaction, the quiet channel's other end — and the price in the dish's emptiness was one knot, unspecified, *his choosing later*. That is his whole game in one dish: not the knot you give him, but the not-knowing which. I thought of Tansy's contract, of the old ones on the ropewalk roof: *he never signs anything that can be settled; read it before you touch it*. And I thought: a cat has one thing a gentleman structurally cannot have, which is the option of walking away from a table with

something already on it.

So I paid him nothing, and I asked my questions anyway, and here is the strangest entry in this whole strange file: *he answered them*. Freely. Precisely. I have come to believe the folder on the table was never the offer; the offer was the conversation, and the conversation was bait of another kind. The Gentleman does nothing that is not collection.

What he told me, with the fog pressing its face to his good windows:

That yes: the night's arrangements had come through his house. Three favors, called blind, brokered without asking — "the not-asking, as the Guildmaster told you, is what the quiet costs; I heard him say it; I hear most things said in rooms I have papered." A cart-slot from the Chandlers. A scattering of seed by a human hand — "the hand was human. Its debt was not." I sat with that sentence while the clock in his hall ticked four minutes behind the world, and it opened like a lattice: some day-sider, indebted to a night-side creditor, worked off the debt with an evening's honest labor, hauling seed to a roofline. The debtor human; the debt's *owner* something else.

"And the third favor?" I asked.

"The third favor," said the Gentleman, "emptied a hall."

The room was very quiet. Even his clock seemed to owe its ticks somewhere.

"I do not know where the Lamplighters went," he said, and I believed him — I, who read rooms for a living, believed him, and I was right to, and being right about him was somehow worse. "I brokered the calling of a debt the hall owed — old oil, older gratitude; guilds are made of such stuff — and the form of the payment was: *be elsewhere, all of you, from seven bells*. Where elsewhere turned out to be was no part of the paper. My clients' purposes are their own. I am a channel, cat. Water does not ask."

"Water," I said, "is what the drowned say too."

Something happened then that I have no language for: the place where his face is *considered* me. "Yes," he said, at length, approvingly, as if I had correctly totaled a column. "You will want to know about my client."

I had not asked. Asking would have been payment — eagerness is

a coin; he mints it. He told me regardless, and every sentence had the weight of a thing given for a reason I could not see. That is the only way he gives anything:

“I never met them. I meet everyone, little rival; I met you before you were worth meeting. This client I have never met. The instructions arrived as instructions sometimes do in my trade: a knot, tied overnight, in my own ledger’s binding-thread — inside my own house — with the commission written in the tying. Close work.” He paused, and the pause was itself close work. “Old-fashioned. I have not seen its like since I was a much smaller concern.”

The Clerk’s voice, unbidden, from a refusal I had not yet had and a night I had already had: *whoever ties these does not care to be noticed*. Two desks, both in the debt trade, one knot-hand neither could file.

“And the payment?” I asked. “What does a client with no face pay a house like this?”

The Gentleman crossed to his shelves, drew out a shallow drawer that had no business fitting between two others, and set its contents on the reading-table beside the untouched folder: a spool. Small, plain, wound with thread of a grey I knew and my whole body did not want to know — the grey of the shroud-seam, the grey of tide-taken things — and wound *tight*, years and years of it.

“Time,” he said. “Stored. Spent-down life, wound and banked. It is not a currency I deal in twice; it does not settle, it only *ends*, and ending is against the interests of my house. But a channel takes the toll the water carries.” He looked at the spool the way Wick had looked at the thread on his blotter. “There are perhaps four beings in Hollowmere who could wind such a spool. I have made inquiries. Three of them are dead, and one of the three is your witch — and the winding is not her hand. It is her hand’s *mirror*.”

He set the spool a half-inch further from the folder, as if the two accounts should not touch. “Price the stock, little rival, as I priced it when it crossed my table. Nothing living winds its own life and survives the winding; what is on that spool was not saved. It was taken. Taken small: a gargoyle’s blink, a street’s held breath, the quiet between a bell and its echo — half-seconds nobody misses, gathered over decades, wound tight, and banked. That is the stock. Under the stock, an advance: something in this city holds lives in

escrow, and it has been extending credit against its holdings. My client did not ask. Water does not ask.”

* * *

I walked home the long way, over the roofs of three districts, because there was too much in the satchel of my chest and walking is how a cat files.

Entered into the case, that morning, in order:

That the murder night was purchased entire — silence, transport, and an emptied hall — through the city’s one channel that never asks, by a client even the channel has not seen.

That the client pays in wound-down life: years off a spool, the coin of the Toll itself, the one currency in Hollowmere that cannot be earned honestly by anything that means to go on living. The Gentleman’s phrase, in my ear the whole way home, keeping time with my feet: *it does not settle, it only ends*.

That the client’s knot-work is close, old-fashioned, mirror-handed — at the Gentleman’s ledger, at my own thread across five refusals I had not fully counted, at a warehouse wall on the Mere-edge. One hand, everywhere, and every place it touched, a professional shrugging: *not one of ours*.

That over Gravamen hums a familiar-thread with one voice in its chord, running toward the water, and I had not followed it, and I told myself it was because the case comes before the curiosities, and the ledger of my chest recorded instead, in the small honest hand it keeps for entries against myself, that I had been *afraid* of where it went.

And that the Quiet Gentleman was now, formally, a suspect — the second strong name on a board that had just lost Wick — and that he knew it, and found it fitting, and had all but pinned himself to my board with his own gloved hands. Guilty of brokering, unasking, of profiting on the night my witch died: certainly. Guilty of the needle-work itself? A being made entirely of open accounts does not spend the one coin that closes them. But a suspect is not crossed off on elegance. He stays, I wrote, until the method rules him out.

The method. Everything now ran through the method: who in this city can spend life like money and stitch like her mirror. I needed

to date the technique — how long had that hand been working? — and for dating old crimes, Hollowmere keeps exactly two archives that never lie. One is under everything, and charges a toll.

The other has been standing on a corner of Wickrow for three hundred years, and it had, I had heard from the pigeons, recently done something unprecedented.

It had blinked.

Chapter 7

The Gargoyle and the Ghost

Sootbeard has watched one street for three hundred years, and last month, he blinked.

You will want the context, because the day-side walks under him daily and sees a rainspout. Sootbeard is the gargoyle on the corner of Wickrow's oldest counting-row: granite shoulders, a beard the soot of thirty thousand chimney-seasons, and the fixed downward glare of a sentry whose watch has never once been relieved. He was installed — he is precise about the word; he did not *perch*, he was *installed*, by masons, with ceremony, under an ordinance — as one of a regiment of civic monuments raised to watch the streets of Hollowmere in the years when the city still remembered what it was watching for. The regiment was decommissioned in 1731. Nobody told him. Or rather — and this is the detail that tells you everything about both parties — somebody *did* tell him, and he declined the order as improperly countersigned, and stayed on watch.

Three hundred years, one street, no relief, no pay, and no blink. Gargoyles do not need to blink; the eyes are granite; the watching is the working. And one night last month, between one lamplighter's lamp and the next, Sootbeard blinked — his first in three centuries — and in the half-second of that blink, something crossed his street unobserved.

He wants it understood that he noticed the blink itself. A lesser monument, he says, would not have.

I heard of it through the pigeon-net, which had resumed operations with the zeal of the reformed and was carrying, among the usual scandal, a strange small item: the gargoyle on Old Counting Row was attempting to file a report, and had been attempting for a month, and there was no one left in the city authorized to receive it.

I went and received it.

I sat on his ledge through a whole turning of the fog while he delivered it, in the voice gargoyles keep — gravel settling in a well — and in the form he had held ready for a month, which was the form of his commissioning, sworn and structured: item, the night; item, the wind; item, the state of the lamps (wrong, he noted, lit wrong for weeks now; he had logged each error; I could have wept for the wasted vigilance of him); item, at four minutes past seven bells by the Horologists' tower — *which runs four minutes slow, adjust accordingly* — an interference; a blink; duration estimated at one half-second; contents of street upon reopening of watch: unchanged; contents of street during closure: *unknown*, and the word came out of him like a stone breaking, because in three hundred years there had never been an unknown in his log.

"Something made me blink," he said. "Nothing makes granite blink, small colleague. Nothing on the schedule of this world. It was not weariness. I do not tire; I erode, and I have three centuries of margin. Something reached into my watching and *spent* it — half a second of my attention, taken and used, the way one takes a coin from a blind man's cup. I wish to report a theft."

A theft of attention. Half a second, lifted clean out of a sentry three hundred years incapable of lapse, on the street his watch made otherwise uncrossable — and the night of it, I confirmed against my ledger with the cold going down my spine like meltwater, was the murder night. Old Counting Row lies on the clean route between Gravamen's quiet channels and Needle Lane. Whoever went to my witch's parlor went through Sootbeard's watch, and paid the crossing with a coin that buys *inattention*, and the coin, I now knew from a gentleman's shelf-drawer, was wound-down life. You do not dodge a gargoyle. You purchase his blink.

"Your report is received," I said, and I meant it as a courtesy, and it landed on him like relief of watch. Three hundred years, and the first receipt. He asked to whom he should henceforth report. I gave

him the truth: to me, for the present, in the matter of the murder of Elspeth Vane. He asked my rank. I considered the file, and the collar, and the strand, and I said: *the Needle's heir, investigating*. Sootbeard saluted — granite grinding on granite, a fist to a brow, dust of three centuries sifting down — and he has saluted me at every meeting since, and I have stopped trying to prevent it, because you cannot argue with an ordinance.

* * *

But a blink has no witness, by construction. That is what it is *for*. So we reconstructed it, Sootbeard and I, from the three witnesses on Old Counting Row that do not have eyelids.

His idea, not mine. Three hundred years of watching teaches you what else watches.

The first witness was the rain barrel at Number Nine. Standing water remembers ripples the way wax remembers heat — poorly, but honestly — and the Weft-side of a barrel's surface holds the pattern of its last true disturbances in a lattice a patient reader can lift. I read it by moonlight, paws on the rim, while Sootbeard recited the month's weather from memory to rule out the innocent rings, storm by storm, cart by cart, drunk by drunk. Under all of it, dated to his blink by the interference-fringe of a lamplighter's footfall he could vouch for: one set of ripples with no source. Rings spreading from a center that held *nothing* — something had passed the barrel closely, at speed, its wake writing on the water while its weight declined to exist. Small, the wake said. Low. Four-footed.

I wrote it in the ledger. The ledger and I did not discuss it.

The second witness was the dog. There is always a dog — Number Fourteen, a wall-eyed old mastiff who sleeps in the areaway and has barked at the night complete and without editorial judgment for eleven years, a colleague of my Number Twelve friend by correspondence of profession. He did not bark at the crossing — of course — but a sleeping dog dreams its street, and dreams keep drafts of what the waking mind was robbed of. I sat with him — this is a thing cats can do, and I will not be explaining it to a species that cannot; it is called listening, and you sit *downwind of the dream* — and in the

draft of that night his street ran quiet and complete, and through it went a shape his dream had tried to bark at and could not, because every time the dream-bark rose, the shape spent something, and the bark *was already over*. The dream remembered the shape the way sleep remembers a fly: an interruption with a silhouette. The silhouette had a tail.

The third witness was the frost.

It was the window of the old assay office, disused, north-facing, the kind of glass that grows the same fern-garden of frost every cold night of its life — and frost-ferns, Sootbeard testified, grow by the breath of the street: every warm exhalation that passes bends the crystals' habit by a hair. On the murder night it had frozen hard. The pane held, pressed in its ferns like a flower in a book, the record of every breath that had gone down Old Counting Row — the lamplighter's, the mastiff's slow tide, a late clerk's gin-warm mutter — and one passage of *no breath at all*: a corridor through the frost-garden where the ferns grew bent around a warmth that had come and gone between two of their branchings, faster than breathing, low to the ground, unbreathed because its bearer had — I understood this in my own chest, with a jolt like a misjudged jump — *held its breath*. As you do. As I do, crossing a watched street, out of a professionalism older than any regiment.

Small. Low. Four-footed. Tailed. Breath held for the crossing.

Sootbeard ground through the same arithmetic beside me, three centuries of watch-craft arriving at the same address, and being Sootbeard, he filed it as a sentry files:

"Parameters, small colleague: small; low; four-footed; tailed; breath held for the crossing. There the report ends. My watch was closed for the duration of the interference. A sentry files what he saw, and I saw nothing. I do not log conclusions my eyes were shut for."

And he stopped, correct to the last grain of him, leaving a silence on the street where the conclusion belonged.

"A thing that has learned to travel as one," I said, first, into that silence — and the ledger of my chest recorded, in the small hand it keeps for entries against myself, that I had reached for that sentence the way a falling man reaches for a gutter, before anyone had said the word I was falling from.

* * *

The residue settled the method; now the method needed a date. And for dating, Sootbeard had one more service, and it cost me what remained of my composure.

The reconstruction wanted checking against the one other recorded blink in the city's history — for there was one; he knew his regiment's logs entire; monuments gossip on a timescale of decades — a blink reported by the gargoyle formerly installed over the Tatterstage door, forty years ago, the night the theater's leading lady died mid-line at her own opening. That gargoyle was decommissioned with the rest and sold for hardcore — crushed for road-fill — when the Tatterstage closed; his log survives only in Sootbeard's memory. To compare fringe-patterns — his word; I have given up resisting his vocabulary — Sootbeard needed to *attend the site*, and Sootbeard cannot fly. He was installed.

Which is how the district of Wickrow was treated, at two of the morning, to the spectacle of a civic monument walking to the theater district — roof-line to roof-line where the timbers would bear him, chimney to chimney like a man fording a river on stones — carrying, in the granite basket of his two cupped fists, held at parade height before him like the regimental colors:

me.

I had explained that I would make my own way. I had explained it twice. Sootbeard had replied that the route bore no relation to a cat's route, that the timing was operational, and that the colleague would be *conveyed* — and this must be said exactly: being carried is an indignity I have tolerated from one person in my life, and she is dead, and I sat in a gargoyle's fists above the sleeping city with the fog going by underneath and the chimneys bowing past like courtiers, and I found that the indignity had somewhere in fifteen years become a thing I missed the way you miss a language. I rode at parade height the whole way and said nothing and my dignity and I have agreed the file may show a redaction here.

The Tatterstage stands — barely — off the old theater square: boarded, bird-limed, its gilt gone the color of weak tea. Its door-gargoyle's empty plinth remains over the architrave like a healed socket. Sootbeard set me down on it, took post on the parapet

opposite with the grinding of a fortress settling, read the sight-lines of his lost colleague for a long silent time, and pronounced: same fringe. Same theft. Same coin, same hand, same *crossing-craft*, forty years apart.

“Your suspect,” he said, “has been stealing half-seconds in this city since before you were littered, small colleague. Report continues below.” A pause; granite eyes on the boarded door. “The house is not empty. It auditions.”

* * *

Every night at the wrong hour, the Tatterstage holds auditions for a play that closed forty years ago. Nobody gets the part.

I went in through the fly-gallery, and I will tell you what the inside of a dead theater is: it is a parlor the size of a guild-hall where the kettle has been screaming for forty years. Dust in curtains of its own; the great chandelier a cocooned moon in its hoist-bag; and on the stage, lit by nothing and visible the way the drowned are dry, a lady in a costume of a fashion two reigns gone, running a scene against the empty house.

The Understudy. That is the name the night-side gives her, with the tenderness this city keeps for its worst-luck cases: she was the understudy who got her chance — one night, the lead’s throat closed by fog, the house full, her name chalked on the board — and she died on that stage mid-line, at her own opening, and she cannot leave until the scene *ends correctly*. That is the shape of her stitch, the loose thread of her: a line unfinished. The Hollow Court could tie her off — it is exactly their trade — but she has declined the service, forty years of politely declining, on the professional grounds that the scene is not over.

And she cannot finish it, because she remembers her death wrong, and rehearses the error.

Nightly she runs the scene toward her exit; nightly, at the fatal line, she directs her scene-partner — whatever shadow or draft or auditioning ghost is to hand — into the wrong blocking, the mistake her memory has enshrined; nightly the scene breaks, and the house sighs, and she begins again. She has directed forty years of auditioners

into her own error. She quotes only from plays — it is all the speech she has left; a whole language of borrowed lines, and she wields it with terrible precision — and when I first came down the fly-rope she looked at me across the dark house and said, from some old comedy: “*Enter the cat, which is more than the management deserves,*” and I was hers from that line onward, and I do not care who knows it.

The true blocking still existed, in three places. (Everything in this city exists in three places; I have stopped finding it strange; Hollowmere is a fabric, and fabric keeps its creases.) The printed programme of the fatal production, with the scene-plot, survived in the collection of a retired prompter — ninety-one years old, sharp as vinegar, resident in a nursing-house whose matron enforces a no-cats ordinance with the zeal of a woman promoted past her judgment; I will say only that ordinances have gaps, that laps were sat in, that the prompter talked to me for two hours the way the lonely talk to cats, reciting the blocking of a forty-year-old tragedy from memory while I purred — Tansy’s purr has re-taught me the trade — and that the matron found nothing amiss but a faint warmth on an old man’s knees.

The chalk ghost-marks were still under the boards of the Tatter-stage itself — the stage manager’s original blocking marks, preserved under forty years of dust like the frost-ferns in the assay glass. And the third witness was the Understudy’s own body: a performer’s feet remember what her grief has rewritten, if you can get her past the place where the memory flinches.

So we performed it. She and I. Cue by cue.

I cannot act — a cat is sincerity armed — but her scene-partner’s part, in the fatal scene, is silent: it enters, it crosses under the practical lamp, it stands where the light falls, and it *receives her line*. Forty years of auditioners had been directed by her, at the crux, to cross behind the lamp — her error, her enshrined mistake — and the scene died there each night because behind the lamp there is no light to die into, and a line delivered into darkness lands on nothing.

I took my blocking from the chalk and the prompter, not from her.

She swept toward the crux; her whole habit turned to direct me into the error — “*No, no, upstage, the shadow, always the shadow*” in a line from some play I hope never to identify — and I stood

where the chalk said. Under the lamp. Downstage. In the light.

And her line found me there, and landed, and I saw forty years of rehearsal come apart in her face like the wisp-lattice — because with the blocking true, she was standing where *she* had stood, saying what she had said, seeing what she had seen, and what she had seen was not what she remembered. The scene ended. Correctly. For the first time.

She stood a long moment in the practical lamp's light, a lady two reigns out of fashion, unpicked at last from her own error, and before the Court's gentle machinery could arrive to tie her off she looked down at me — her final audience, her one correct scene-partner — and gave me her exit line. Her own. Not borrowed. The only unquoted sentence, I believe, that she had spoken in forty years, and the reader of this file will understand that I would rather report almost anything else, because I had come there for evidence, and I have never since been able to decide what I received:

"It was not the fog that stopped his breath, little one," she said. "The fog was *bought*. I saw the half-second come into the house — I was in the wings, where you see everything — I saw it cross under my lamp, low, and take the prompt-breath out of the night, and my line went out into a silence that had been *purchased*, and the house heard my heart refuse, and I have been forty years blaming my own feet."

Then, quieter, as if handing over a property she had held for the run of the show: "And write into your file what the bills never carried, little one: my lady was a stitcher. She kept a seam under the greasepaint — silver, at the hairline; I painted it over every night and asked no questions, because an understudy sees everything and says nothing."

She straightened. Curtsied to the empty house, to the cocooned chandelier, to me.

"Tell them the notice was wrong," she said. "The performance did not fail. It was *robbed*. And so, small colleague of the wings — so were you."

She took her bow. The house lights of some better theater came up for her, somewhere I could not follow, and the Tatterstage was, at last, only a building.

* * *

I sat on the empty stage a long time with the practical lamp cooling beside me, doing the sum the whole chapter had assembled, and it would not come out any way but one.

The technique was forty years old. The lead whose throat closed — a stitcher, one of Cardew's *twice before; the fog was bought*; the half-second under the lamp; a death arranged so that an understudy's heart would break on schedule — the hand that murdered my witch had been working in this city for forty years, patient, close, mirror-handed, spending life like small coin. Forty years. The Circuit's rival witches, the guild's men, the whole day-side gallery of plausible suspects — I ran them through the new arithmetic that night and watched them fall out of it one by one, too young, too new, too *mortal*. What in Hollowmere is forty years at a craft and still working? Witches, a few. Gargoyles. Ghosts. The Gentleman, whose house is older than the question.

And cats, said the ledger, in the small hand, are allotted nine lives, and I have stood in the Clerk's corridor six times this season — once on the docket, five times REFUSED, a distinction he maintains and I have stopped disputing — and am writing this book.

The ledger, having opened that page, would not shut it politely. There is a grey at the Court of Whiskers — the senior of the deputation that serves our papers, oldest of the old ones on the ropewalk roof — a tom of the right vintage, grown and working forty years ago. I entered him. I hated every stroke of the entry, and I said nothing to anyone.

Something crossed a sentry's street shaped as a cat. Something took the prompt-breath out of a theater, low, under the lamp. Something taught wisps a route, and travels the overstreets as if born to them, and cuts a familiar-thread with one clean bite, and ties close old-fashioned knots that neither death's clerks nor debt's gentleman can file — and over Gravamen, humming toward the water, hangs a familiar-thread with one voice in the chord, and I had not followed it, and I was running out of ways to tell myself why.

Forty years ago, something happened in this city worth a lifetime of half-seconds.

I needed the Remembered Days. All of them. And the only way

to them was to sleep in the places where it is least safe for me to sleep, which is a sentence my witch would have underlined twice and forbidden once, and she is dead, and the forbidding has lapsed, and the underlining stands.

Chapter 8

The Remembered Days

Before the dreams, the living. Two more of them enter the file here, and one of the two is a suspect.

The Witches' Circuit convened at the quarter-moon, in the long room above the Assay Court that they have used since before the Assay Court existed, and Mother Cardew brought me in under her cloak-hem, which is to say: she opened the door, looked at me sitting in the corridor, said "the cat is with me," and dared eight empty chairs and seven occupied ones to comment.

Nine seats. One empty in the way that seats are empty when someone has died — draped, honored, unspeakable. And one empty in the way that seats are empty when someone is *late*, which in that room is its own scandal.

The Circuit maintains the Hush. That is the whole of their charter: nine working witches, each holding a district's worth of seams, together holding the great old binding that keeps Hollowmere's two sides politely separate. They are paid like plumbers and respected like surgeons and they frightened me, all seven, the way competence frightens: these were hands that could have tied me off like a loose thread. And every one of them, I saw within a minute, was more frightened than I was. The Needle was dead. The Needle's seams — her whole district's worth, and the other thing, the great thing nobody at that table would name with a cat present — wanted a new Needle, and the seven of them together, Cardew said later, without bitterness, as a surgeon reports a margin: *could not sew one year of her decade*.

The late seat arrived. Mistress Shear.

I will describe her fairly, because the file demands it and because I came, in the end, almost to pity her. Sharp-boned, quick, dressed a half-degree finer than the room; a candidate's hunger worn thin over real skill — she is not a fraud; I watched her hands the whole session and the hands are good, journeyman-good, lattice-good. She had petitioned for the ninth seat twice while Elspeth lived and been declined twice, because the ninth seat is the Needle's seat and she does not have the hand, and everyone at the table knew it, and she knew they knew, which is the specific acid that etches ambition into something worse.

She spoke correctly of the dead. She moved correctly through the agenda. And when the session closed she stayed behind the others to examine, with correct and scholarly interest, the sampler of Elspeth's stitching that the Circuit keeps under glass.

I watched her want it. Her hands came up over the case and stopped — a half-inch off the glass, spread, held — the way a paw hangs over water with a fish in it: everything committed, nothing yet spent. She stood like that longer than she knew, her face doing the correctness and her hands doing the truth, and in the glass under her fingers, reflected, the draped ninth chair. Then the hands came down to the frame's edge, and she examined the sampler *mirror-wise*, tracing the lines right to left, and my whole pelt stood up, quietly, under the draped chair where I had failed to leave with Cardew.

I took that to Brindle, because appetite for technique leaves receipts, and the Exchange reads receipts.

It took the Magpie three dawns and cost me the redeeming of the thimble — which I had always meant to redeem; the transaction, for what it is worth, was a pleasure on both sides of the counter. What Brindle's paper-net brought up was this: some weeks before the murder, a circular had moved through the quiet channels — *the* quiet channels; fog-smelling paper; no signature but a small inked knot — offering for sale, to a discreet and qualified buyer, "the Needle's hand, demonstrated and taught." Stolen technique. The stitch of Elspeth Vane, on the market, while Elspeth Vane was alive.

And Mistress Shear had answered it. Paid earnest-money — heavily; there were promissory notes in the Exchange's tributary streams with her careful signature on them — and received, by way of demon-

stration, a sample: a hand's length of warding, unpicked in the Vane stitch, mirror-handed, delivered to her workroom inside a locked box she swears was never unlocked.

Then: nothing. No teaching, no second contact, her notes uncollected, her earnest-money never drawn. The seller had dangled the one thing her hunger could not refuse, proved it real, taken her name — and vanished, leaving her holding a sample of the exact technique that would shortly unpick a murder scene.

You see what that made her. Suspect the third: a witch with the motive of an empty seat, the ambition of two declined petitions, and *physical possession of the murder method*, bought on paper that smelled of fog. The fair reading and the foul reading of Mistress Shear arrived together and sat on my board refusing to share the pin.

* * *

The second entry came up from the Mereside, as everything in this half of the book comes up from the Mereside, with wet footprints that were not wet.

A caulker on the drowned terraces had sold his shadow years ago — men do, down there; the pawnshops of the impossible advance real coin on one — and years on, the shadow came home. It hung itself correctly off his heels and set about his life, and it was *better at his life than he was*: it paid the arrears his shame had let stand, watered the fern, answered his estranged daughter's letters in a hand like his hand mended. She was coming to visit, the first time in six years, and the man wanted the shadow gone. I took the case because I am a creature with a nine-pocketed shadow sewn by a dead woman's hand; the file was always going to find me.

Two nights of shadowing a shadow settled it. The shadow was not his. It was a rag-wraith — but one that wore not clothes but a *silhouette*, the whole outline of a man, and it was not attacking anyone. It was rehearsing. A man's evenings, a man's kindnesses, a man's handwriting — practicing being human, carefully, getting it right — because its own man is one of the missing, and it had apprenticed itself to the nearest empty life that matched its shape.

I sat on the caulker's wall at three in the morning with the borrowed shadow beside me, and I asked it where its own man had gone. It did not speak; wraiths do not. It *pointed* — the first I have ever heard of one pointing — one long silhouette-arm, unhurried, certain, out past the sea-wall, at the black glass of the water.

And sitting beside it in the dark, I noticed what I should have noticed two nights sooner. A wraith whose owner is spent frays inside a season; everyone on the night-side knows the sad lint of them, coming apart at the cuffs of themselves. This one was crisp as new laundry. Its man was held somewhere, whole, and it knew, and it was keeping his evenings pressed and ready against a homecoming it had no date for. I filed the distinction formally, in the chest-ledger, where the case could reach it: *held is not spent*.

The missing drain toward the Mere. The wax feeds toward the Mere. Her thread was cut over the Mere. The one-voiced familiar-thread hums toward the Mere. I thanked the shadow, formally. It bowed the way its man must once have bowed, and went back to the fern.

I told the Court of Whiskers what the shadow was; the Court told the pawnshop; and night-side law, which is older than mercy but not unrelated to it, ruled the man's pledge lapsed and his own true shadow returnable on payment of interest. The interest was: the wraith keeps its evenings at the fern. I was on the wall when the daughter came. The door opened before her knock — the man himself, flat-lit, trembling, unassisted — and I watched her face do the arithmetic: the answered letters against the shaking hand, the mended writing against the man in the doorway, six years against one step over the sill. She went in. The wraith sits with them some evenings, in the correct chair, rehearsing. Nobody minds.

* * *

And then I went hunting the past deliberately, and the way you hunt the past is: you sleep where it is not safe to sleep.

I had the shape of the thing by then. The Remembered Days come on the pale strength; they are Moonlight spending itself as memory when it cannot spend as anything else, and they come strongest

where the body lies down inside old danger — some economy in the unfinished magic she left me that pays out her past against my risk, a purse that opens only when the paw trembles. Sleep on the hearthrug and you dream of dinner. Sleep on the Wickhouse rafters over the water wall, over the fed thing turning below, and—

Warm. Lamplight. The table. The chart of the water wall, half-sewn, and me small and certain on the middle of it, and her voice above, amused, talking to the needle: "That winter I tried eight strays. . . "

I have given the reader that one already. But dreams, revisited, keep drafts, like the mastiff's street: this time it ran longer. This time her needle stopped, in the dream, and her hand came down and rested on the small sleeping certainty of me, and she said — to the cat on the chart, to the room, to the accounts she was forever keeping in the margins of herself — "Nine is the correct number. Nine is the number I owe." And the needle went back to the wall-chart, and the word *owe* went into me like a splinter too fine to find again once it is in.

I slept on the sea-wall at the Mereside edge, in the fog's own doorway, with Sootbeard — who had insisted; the operational posture of the watch, he said, extends to colleagues sleeping irregularly — standing over me like a monument to bad decisions. And I dreamed the forty-year night.

I will report it as it came, in pieces, because it came in pieces and I do not trust myself to smooth it.

Nine bells. That is the first piece and it rang through all the others: the tower giving its full old count, one to nine, and the ninth bell's voice was deep and certain and it is the only time I have ever heard it, awake or asleep, and I knew it instantly the way you know a name called across a market: the city used to have one more hour of night, and the hour had a bell, and the bell was rung that evening on purpose, because the working needed the whole nine.

The barge. Black water lying dead calm and lightless, and out on it, a barge without a bargeman, and the Circuit of forty years ago on the quays with every lamp in the city turned toward the Mere — and the lamps' order mattering; the Lamplighters walking their sequence like a loom's shuttle, lighting a pattern across the whole town, the entire city made into a stitching-frame; I woke with my

paws working and slept back down into it.

Her. Young — younger than I ever knew her, hair dark, hands already hers — going out onto the black glass *alone*, on foot, on the water, which held her the way paper holds ink, because the working wanted the Needle and no other weight. And the fog on the far shore stood up in shapes that were not the fog, and under the water something *hoped* — I felt it hope, in the dream, the way you feel thunder through the pads — something old and patient and vast, risen the whole way to the underside of the surface, pressed against the world like a face against glass. The Mere, before the seam. What the city was, that season. What all the lamps were for.

The grey shape. At the edge of every piece of the dream, close to her skirts, on the black water where nothing else could walk except her and it: a smallness. Grey. Four-footed. The dream kept it at the corner, always at the corner — dreams are tactful; hers especially; even remembered, she was minding what a cat should see — but I know how a familiar stands to a witch at work. I have stood so for fifteen years. The grey shape stood so.

The seam. And then the working itself, which I cannot render and will not try beyond this: she sewed the lake shut. Standing on it. Stitch by stitch across a closing that ran from the Wickhouse shore to the far fog, her needle taking the light of the ordered lamps as thread takes wax, the ninth bell tolling the measure — and each great stitch had to be *paid at the pull*, the way all her work was paid, costs visible, nothing free; and I watched the payments go: memory — a whole quarter of the sky of the dream went dark and stayed dark; warmth — the winter that followed was in her hands for the rest of her life; luck; years.

And then the working reached the last stitches, the anchor of the whole seam, and the price of an anchor is not memory or warmth or luck or years, and I saw — at the corner, at the tactful terrible corner of the dream — eight small lights go out of the grey shape at her skirts, one at a time, each one drawn down her needle into the stitching like beads onto a string, eight lives pulled out of a living familiar and sewn into the bottom of the lake, and the grey shape did not run, and that is the detail I woke on, both times I have dreamed it since: *it did not run*. It stood to her, the way a familiar stands, while it was spent.

She came back off the water alone.

The dream would not show me the shape's face. I have said dreams are tactful. But it showed me her ledger — the one she kept in the margins of herself, where I had heard her write the word *owe* — and the entry the working made there, and the entry was: *eight*. And fifteen years ago, on a chart-table, to a sleeping stray, the same voice said: *nine is the number I owe*.

Eight spent. Nine owed. She was not keeping count of strays for whimsy. She was doing what she did with every debt in her shambles of accounts: rounding *up*, against interest, and paying forward the only way cat-magic pays.

* * *

I woke on the sea-wall in the grey before dawn with Sootbeard's granite watching over me and the fog going out on the ebb, and I lay still a long time, doing what I had been refusing to do since a roof in Gravamen, which was: drawing the line between the nines.

Forty years ago, my witch sewed the Mere shut and paid the anchor of the seam with eight lives that were not hers. Her familiar of that era — grey, spent, unpaid — went missing from every record I have ever heard recited, and *missing-not-dead* is the category this entire case has been orbiting like a moth at a shutter: the coats, the wraiths, the Court's returned filings. The technique that killed her is forty years old, works in her mirrored hand, and spends stored life as coin — and the only account in the city that ever held stored life in that quantity was emptied into the bottom of the lake, all but one.

And the thing under the water, which hoped, has been *finding* things ever since the seam began to loosen: finding wax, finding the missing, finding — the world-bible of my own pelt told me, there on the cold stone — someone. It has found someone. Someone with forty years of grievance and one life left and her exact stitch learned from in front, mirror-wise, across a decade of lamplit evenings on the near side of the work.

I did not write the name. Even in the chest-ledger, even in the small hand. Some entries, once made, cannot be unpicked, and I am my witch's heir in this above everything: I do not sew what I am not yet prepared to pay for.

But I stood up on the sea-wall, and I looked out at the flat black glass, and then up, at the one-voiced familiar-thread humming its long grey line over the city, toward the water, toward the fog that holds its shapes too long.

The pigeons of the Mereside roosts, I noticed, were silent. Still. Again. The quiet roosts: the silence had never really lifted down here, this close to the water — it had been *bought* here first, and bought deepest.

Whatever I believed and was refusing to believe, the next thing was the same either way. Follow the thread. All the way. To whatever is on the end of it.

I went home first, and slept the honest kind of sleep, and ate the breakfast Tansy had saved me half of — she saves me half; I have given up litigating it — and I sharpened every claw I own on the doorpost of a dead woman's house, and then I went to spend some lives.

Chapter 9

The Quiet Roosts

The thread ran south-southwest, high and taut and tended, and I followed it the way you follow a river to the sea: knowing where it goes, going anyway.

I want to say a word about *tended*, because it is the word that mattered. Threads slacken. Even great cables sag between their tyings, and a familiar-thread whose witch-end has gone silent should hang like washing-line in rain — I know; mine does; I groom around it daily and we do not discuss it, my thread and I. This one was taut as a harp's business half across the city, and where the roofline winds had frayed it, it was *mended* — neat grey splices, close work, old-fashioned, at intervals of years. Somebody had been maintaining a dead line for four decades, the way you maintain a grave, or a grudge, or a hope.

It crossed the Shambles high over Brindle's stall. It crossed Wick-row within sight of Sootbeard's corner, and I wondered, passing, how many of its menders' crossings his log had never held. And then it began to descend, wide and slow, the way a gull descends, down the terraces of the Mereside, toward the water — and it dipped, before the water, at the roosts.

The quiet roosts. I had been hearing the phrase all season the way you hear a dripping tap: the Mereside dovecotes, the oldest pigeon-fastness in the city, from which the Post's silence had never really lifted. Toby's seed, the bought election, the murder-night hush — all of it had washed out of the upper city with the seed audit. Down here it had not washed out. Down here, I discovered that night, there

was nothing left to wash.

The roosts were empty.

Not roosting-elsewhere empty. Empty the way the Lamplighters' hall was empty: coats over boots. Dovecote after dovecote, terrace after terrace, the little wooden cities of the pigeon-nation stood open to the fog — droppings gone chalky with weeks, seed rotting in the throats of the feeders, nest-bowls holding cold eggs that no accounting anywhere will ever settle — and over it all the deep wrong Mereside silence, which I now understood was not the absence of pigeon-noise but the *presence* of something else: the hush you hear inside a bell after it has been stopped with a hand.

One bird remained.

He was old past flying, blind in both eyes, deaf — I judged — to everything but vibration, and he sat his empty rail in the greatest dovecote like a postmaster at a closed counter, and he was, I realized as I came up the ladder-holes making my footfalls heavy so as not to lie to him, the only creature in that whole city of the missing who had never once been asked for his testimony, because who would climb to ask it? A cat climbed. The last witness of the quiet roosts gave his deposition to a cat, feeling the questions through the wood of the rail.

What he gave me, in the pidgin of taps and stillnesses we built between us over an hour: the quiet had not come with the murder. The quiet had come up the chimneys *years* ago, slow as damp — first the dreams going out of the squabs, then the gossip going out of the elders, then, roost by roost, the going. Not flight. Going. *Down*. They went to the water to be paid, he tapped — I have turned the phrase every way and it does not improve — they went to the water to be paid, and the payment was the quiet, and the quiet was already here.

The seed on the upper roofs bought a single night of silence from the living. Down here, the silence had been bought outright, and forever, whole roosts of the Post's oldest stock drawn down toward the black glass over years — fed forward, the way the wax was fed, the way the coats' owners were fed — to the account of the patient thing whose seam was loosening one stolen half-second at a time.

I left the old bird my second-to-last strip of dried herring, wedged where his rail meets the post. He stood on one foot upon it, which

among the Post is the taking of salt, and he tapped one thing more, unasked, as I went down the ladder-holes: *the mender comes at the neap*. The mender. Comes at the neap tide, when the water is furthest withdrawn and the flats lie bare. He had felt the mender's footfalls on the roost-boards for forty years, four small drumbeats, lighter than a gull's — and the mender's visits and the goings-down, he wanted me to know, feeling my weight on his rail like a set of scales — the visits and the goings had *kept different calendars*. The mender tended the thread. Something else emptied the roosts. Two hands on the Mereside, the old bird was telling me, and he had outlasted them both, and could tell them apart blind, and nobody had asked.

I have thought since about how much of this book was given to me by witnesses everyone else had walked past: a rain barrel, a sleeping dog, a frost-pane, a blind bird on a dead rail. She used to say the city never stops testifying; there is only the question of who has the manners to take the deposition.

* * *

It was the neap.

I had known it was the neap when I set out; the tide-tables are posted at the fish market and a cat who intends to trespass on the Mereside consults them. I tell myself now — I told myself then — that I went down to the flats because the thread's last descent crossed them, and the knot in its lowest slack could be read nowhere else. That was true. Everything I have ever told myself has been true. I have learned this season what truth is for, and I no longer make the mistake of confusing it with innocence: I went down to the flats at the neap because the mender came at the neap, and some part of me, older than the case and worse at arithmetic, wanted to *see*.

The Mere at neap-ebb is a landscape from the underside of dreams: black flats shining like a spilled mirror, the fog withdrawn to a waiting distance, the sea-wall's weed-line hanging overhead like the tide's own high-water ledger. The thread came down out of the dark in one long grieving curve and ran its final length a paw's height over the flats, out past the last stone, toward the deep pool that never ebbs, where the seam — I knew now, I had dreamed the sewing of it — lay anchored in the bottom of the world.

And in its lowest slack, just past the last stone, there was a knot. I could see it from the wall. Close work. Old-fashioned.

I want the record to show that I saw the rest coming, and went anyway. This was not Gravamen's alley, not weather merely arriving. The fog stood off the flats in a horseshoe, waiting with the manners of an usher; the pools between the stones lay too still; the Drowned do not hide and were not hiding — I counted five of them, spaced across the flats like pieces already moved, dry-footed on the wet mirror, arriving at nothing, which meant the arriving was for later, which meant it was for me. Every whisker, every professional instinct, every windowsill lesson said: this is the price of the reading. The appointment was announced, as the Clerk had promised. I saw it a long way off.

I paid it.

I went out over the flats fast and low, spending as I went — the dark stretches taken soundless, the two gaps where arriving became arrival taken at a flat sprint that left my heart loud on the wrong side of my ribs, and at the cold places, where the mirror reached up through my pads like a hand, something of hers going out of me to meet it until the cold changed its mind — and I reached the last stone, and I read the knot with my nose an inch from forty years of close grey splicing, and I learned the two things I had come to learn.

First: the knot was kin to the knots on my own thread. Not similar. *Kin* — the same hand's habit, the same tuck and doubling, the mend of a mender who learned mending in one particular lamplit parlor. I had carried its brothers at my own chest through every refusal at the Clerk's desk and never once been able to look at them squarely.

Second, and I had not come to learn it and it has never left me: a familiar-thread hums with its two lives, a chord. This one, an inch from my ear, hummed its single sustaining note, and the note was in *her key*. Strung by her hand, tuned by her tying, the twin of the thread I wear. Whatever hung at the far end of this line, out past the last stone, under the black glass or over it, my witch had bound it to herself once, the way she later bound me — and it had answered her working the way I answer, and its half of the chord was the half mine will make when I am gone.

There was a third thing. I had not come for it, and it did not wait to be asked.

A lamp came down the terraces behind me, swinging on a round that does not exist. I knew the walk before I knew the man — a lamplighter's pace, steady as chalk-strokes — and then I knew the man: Fenn, whose round Merrow rated the steadiest of her remaining four, the same lamplighter who had put his face in his hands the night I mended the hall's ward. He came down the sea-stair and out onto the mirror with his lamp lit and his eyes open and nothing behind them. I ran at him. I put myself under his boots and made every noise I own, and he stepped around me the way you step around furniture in a house you have lived in all your life, and set his lamp down on the mud, and walked into the horseshoe of fog, and the fog leaned in from three sides and folded him away standing. It was quick, and it was gentle, and it is the worst thing I have watched in this city. His lamp went on burning where he left it.

Then the fog spoke to me.

It has no voice of its own. It has never needed one. It holds the voices of everyone it has taken — held, in escrow, unspent — and it spent some now, one sentence at a time, each sentence in a different mouth.

"Stand aside," it said, in an old lamplighter's voice, the voice of a man whose route has walked him longer than he walked it.

"Let the seam open," it said, in a woman's voice with the roost-keeper's burr in it.

"And we walk home tomorrow," it said, in a child's voice. "On the morning ebb. All of us."

The offer was plain and I will report it plainly. Not power. Not my lives back. Not the case. The coats filled; the boots claimed; the roosts loud by noon; Merrow's chalk-tally ended at last; every missing name in this book walking up the terraces in one grey morning — against one cat standing aside from one seam. It had priced me correctly. It did not offer me a single thing for myself.

I listened to every voice it spent, and the last voice was Fenn's — five minutes held, and lent back already — and Fenn's voice said, "It is warm down here, cat." That was the only sentence in the whole transaction I believe was a lie.

And under the listening I did the one thing I am for. I audited. Voice after voice, mouth after mouth, the whole inventory of the city's held — and one voice was not in it, and could not be in it,

and was never going to be in it. The Mere returns what it holds; it holds the missing, whole, at the bottom of the world. She is not at the bottom of the world. She is nowhere a lake can reach. Dead is not held; spent is spent; it is her own iron law, and the lake, of all creditors, keeps it. If it could have said one sentence in her voice, I think it would have owned me. It could not, and it knew it could not, and so it stood there in its ring, holding out a city.

“No,” I said.

Fenn’s lamp burned on the mud between us, and I made myself look at it while I said the rest, because a refusal is cheap until you price it in other people’s coats.

“I am her estate. The estate declines. The seam stays sewn. I will find another way to bring them up — and if there is none, charge that to me. Not to her seam.”

The fog took the horseshoe apart without hurry. The voices went back into escrow. The lamp on the mud went out — not blown; drunk — and the dark that came down over the flats was the Mere being done with negotiating.

The tide does not run at the neap. The Mere is not the tide.

The water came up the flats in one silent folding, unhurried, total, like a page being turned by something reading in bed, and the five Drowned arrived all at once from five directions into the place where I was, and I had spent what I had crossing out, and the last thing I did with the last of my breath was the thing my whole training had been for: I looked. Four seconds. Longer. Down through the black turning glass toward the pool that never ebbs, where something vast lay against the underside of the world with the patience of owed money — looking back up at me with what a lake has instead of a face, and *hoping* — and past it, at the edge, at the tactful corner of my own drowning, four small drumbeats on the mirror-flats, lighter than a gull’s, going away.

The cold went. Then the noise. Then the part of me that was worried about the noise. The offer stayed.

* * *

“Back so soon,” said the Clerk. “The form remembers you, which saves us both time.”

The desk. The lamp. The queue of one. This was no refusal and both of us knew it: the appointment had been posted on the flats in five standing figures and I had kept it with my eyes open. My second true death, of nine. The Toll was taken, and I will state plainly what it took, because it was not a quantity. The Clerk consulted the schedule, and the schedule named its fee, and the fee was a Remembered Day — one, particular, itemized in the Court's short hand. The chart-table. The lamplit evening at the half-sewn wall-chart, me small and certain in the middle of her work, her voice above, amused, talking to the needle: *That winter I tried eight strays*. It went across the desk whole, the way a coin goes: entirely, and to someone else. I keep the words — they are in the chest-ledger, in the small hand, and notes are not the thing. The warmth of that table belongs to the Hollow Court now. He took it professionally, and almost gently, and neither helped. And the stamp with its paw-print came down on a page that did not say REFUSED, and the not-saying sat in the corridor's cold light like a stone.

Then came the measuring.

Part of the form of a true death — I had not known; the first time, the night of the parlor, I had been past noticing — is the thread-audit: the Clerk draws your thread out along the brass rule set into his desk's edge, reads its length against the ledger, and files the difference. He drew mine. He read it. He stopped.

He ran it back through his fingers, slowly, spectacles down, to the first of the small grey knots — the mends I have carried since the refusals began, the knots I have groomed around and not discussed with myself — and he examined it for a long time, and then the next, and the next, and I sat in the cat-sized chair (there is a cat-sized chair now; it appeared at the fifth or sixth visit; neither of us has ever mentioned it) and watched death's own clerk confront a document he could not file.

"There is work on this thread that is not ours," he said, at last. "I have noted it before. I have written CLERICAL ERROR, once, and I do not write fiction, as a rule." He looked at me over the spectacles. "Close work. Old-fashioned. Whoever ties these does not care to have them noticed — and they are *mends*, sir. Someone has been re-tying you. Your arithmetic will not balance because it is being balanced from outside, between my audits, by a hand that pays nothing in

and takes nothing out and appears in no schedule of this Court.” He laid the thread down with the exaggerated evenness of a man mastering an emotion unbecoming to his office. “Your file is the thickest irregularity below this city, and it is attracting *attention*, and I find—” he stopped, and turned the lamp up a degree, which I had learned by then to read as the outer limit of his tenderness, “—I find I no longer altogether mind. Go carefully. That is not in the form.”

He was not quite done. He turned the ledger back to the season’s first page, and laid one translucent finger on an entry there, and left it a moment without comment. “One thing more, sir. Your first death. The parlor. It kept an appointment — and this Court did not post it. The line for the posting hand is blank.” He looked at the blank the way he had looked at the knots. “I have kept this desk a long time. I have never once seen that line blank.”

He walked me out himself, that visit. Down the corridor of shelves — and it was in the corridor, at a cross-aisle I had passed on every visit and never once turned down, that the whole third part of this book announced itself, because something in the dark of the cross-aisle *breathed*.

One long bronze note, below hearing, felt in the floor: the sound a great bell makes in its sleep, years after the last time it was rung, when a footfall crosses its vault. I stopped. The Clerk stopped. Down the cross-aisle, behind a grille, on an evidence-shelf built to a scale the rest of the shelving only rumors, lay a bell the size of a parlor — green-shouldered, dust-shrouded, its docket hanging from its crown on grey ribbon like a toe-tag.

“Ah,” said the Clerk. “Yes. The Ninth.”

He said it the way you name a colleague’s old scandal. And standing in that corridor, freshly dead for the second time, with my thread full of another creature’s mercy and my chest full of black water, I received at last the answer to the first wrong thing I ever noticed — eight bells from the tower, and no ninth any more — and the answer was: *pawned*. The ninth bell of Hollowmere was pawned to the Hollow Court a century ago, by the city itself, in council, under seal — collateral against a plague-season’s worth of unpaid Tolls — and never redeemed. The docket is open to this day. And since the night they hauled it down, said the Clerk, in the tone of a man

quoting a finding he had signed and not liked, the city's nights have run one hour short: the ninth hour of the dark was rung by the ninth bell, and an hour that is never rung is never *kept*, and so it pools down here with the rest of the unclaimed. Nobody in Hollowmere has dreamed their last dream to the end in a hundred years. Every sleeper in the city wakes one hour early and calls it morning, and the ninth bell sleeps in an evidence vault with the whole unspent hour of the city banked in its bronze, accruing.

"It did not only ring the hours," the Clerk added, in the tone of a footnote. "The hours kept the appointments."

The working of forty years ago had rung nine bells; I had heard them in the Remembered Day, and the ninth had been rung *out of this vault* — signed out, the docket showed, for one night, on the Circuit's surety, for the great sewing; and returned. The last time it spoke. Her seam was rung shut on a pawned bell's borrowed voice.

"The docket remains unresolved," said the Clerk, and dusted nothing off the grille's brass. "The Court does not forgive collateral, and the city has never once petitioned for redemption. It would take—" and he permitted himself the thing that in the Clerk stands where other men keep smiling, a small dry ceremonial pause, "—a paperwork error. There is always a paperwork error. Locating it, however, is a profession."

He looked at me. I looked at the bell.

The stairs up are longer than the fall down. They always are. I climbed them that night with the case entire on my back — three suspects on the board, a fourth in the log, and my one unwritten name under it; a method forty years old that spends lives for half-seconds; a thread in her key running out past the last stone; a mender who comes at the neap and re-ties a dead witch's cat between audits; the missing, the wax, the roosts, all draining down one slope toward a patient hope under black glass — and the shape of the third part of this book assembling itself in me stair by stair, out of a clerk's dry hint and a bell's held hour.

The Mere is fed on the missing and the quiet, and it is winning, softly, one unpicked seam at a time. Against a thing like that, claws are a rumor. *Paperwork* is an appointment.

Tansy was asleep on the hearthrug when I came in, in the exact center of it, compassed by one chewed bootlace; she had waited up,

the room said, and lost. Under the door, in Brindle's counting-hand, was the answer to a question I had paid her to put about before I went down: where the senior grey of the Court of Whiskers deputation had passed the night of the neap. *Nowhere that paper reaches* — not at the Ratsmeet, not at any roost the Exchange prices. It did not clear him, and I left him in the log, off the board, and the leaving was not free.

I stood a while at the board on the chimney breast, and then I took a pin, and under the whole assembly of the case — the stub, the docket, the counterfoil, the blank card, the shroud-thread, the grey wool running toward Gravamen — I pinned the one new exhibit I had carried up the long stairs, which was a sentence, mine, in the small honest hand:

The city is owed an hour, and I know where it is banked.

Then that is where we are going.

Part III

The Ninth Bell

Chapter 10

The Slow Clock and the Escrow Key

The Horological Society's master clock runs four minutes slow. The Horologists know why. They are not fixing it.

I went to Gravamen because I was sent for. The Clerk had told me my file was attracting attention, and here was the attention, days later, under my own door: a letter from the Horological Society, sealed in wax the color of brass, requesting the assistance of *the party of the irregular filings* in a matter of time owed. The Horologists owe the Court *time*, literally, under contracts older than their tower, and a guild that owes the Court its own currency hears of everything irregular on the Court's books — and a cat who intends to spring a bell from an evidence vault by paperwork had better apprentice himself to somebody, so I went. I did not arrive, this once, in the middle of somebody's catastrophe. The catastrophe had read my file, and sent for me by name.

The rounds that week had handed me my first failure as heir. The fish-market hem — the first ward I stitched on my own authority, not mending her work but making mine — let go inside a week. My stitch, not hers, and nobody came in the night to save it. I went back and did it again, uglier and deeper into the old cloth of the wall, and the second stitching holds to this day. I carried that to Gravamen like a stone in a boot: the standing was inherited. The hand is not. The hand you buy by doing a thing twice.

The Society's tower is a marvel: a building that is one instrument,

every floor a wheel-train, the bones of it ticking like a chest full of hearts. Its master clock governs the district — every counting-house regulator, every undertaker's hall clock, every watchman's turnip sets itself by the tower — and for eleven years, I now know, the tower has lied to all of them by a growing margin, because for eleven years, every night, the Horologists have been *skimming*. Four minutes here, a matter of seconds there, shaved off the district's clocks in the dead watch, gathered, wound onto a mainspring of appalling beauty in the tower's crown — hoarded.

For their founder.

He is dying, the old master who built the tower's heart — he has been dying for years with the stubbornness of his own escapements — and the Society holds a contract, his first commission, signed by the city in an age when the city still signed such things: one sunrise, owed to him, dated *on completion of the great work*. The great work was completed forty years ago — his hands set the tower's crown-wheel the same season my witch walked out on the black glass; this city's debts all keep the same anniversaries — and the sunrise was never paid; there was a war of lawyers, and the paper slept. He will not survive to spring. The sunrise he is owed will rise without him unless it is *brought forward* — and you cannot bring a sunrise forward, but you can, if you are a guild of desperate clockmakers, assemble one out of hoarded minutes: eleven years of skimmed time, spent all at once, one impossible golden hour over Hollowmere, out of schedule, with the old man's chair carried up to the tower gallery to meet it.

Hoarding time is Toll evasion, and the Court's auditors had noticed eleven years of the district's minutes failing to reconcile, and were en route.

The Society laid it all before me the way the city has learned to lay things before me: on a table, at night, with the door barred, half in hope and half in shame. What they wanted was a miracle. What they had was — the Clerk's own phrase, arrived at last — *a paperwork error*. The right kind.

Here is the whole of the law of it in plain words, once, so that the reader need never practice it: the Horologists were not stealing time. They were taking back time the city owed them — one sunrise, promised in writing, forty years past due — and they had the paperwork to prove it. The trade calls that a *lien*, and a lien is

not evasion; it only has manners to keep: the taking-back declared, itemized, and spent in the open, before witnesses, with the balance struck.

They stared at me. I am told — by Tansy, who had ridden along uninvited in the usual manner and sat through the council on the table's edge washing her ears with unbearable magisterial calm — that I had begun, at some point in the exposition, to pace the table the way *she* used to pace a hem.

The auditors arrived at dawn: two of them, grey-gloved, correct, with the Court's unhurried courtesy and dockets already opened. And the Society, coached to the syllable, did not hide the mainspring. They *declared* it. Laid the sunrise contract on the bench beside eleven years of skimming-ledgers — they had kept ledgers; they are Horologists; they could no more skip an entry than skip a tooth on a wheel — and petitioned, formally, to discharge the city's oldest unpaid debt of light by public performance, all parties to witness, the Court to meter the spend and certify the balance.

I watched two auditors of the Hollow Court confront a filing that was irregular, enormous, and *correct*, and I watched them fall in love. They stayed three days. They re-metered the mainspring twice for the pleasure of it. They found against the Society on two counts of procedure and waived both fees in consideration of *exceptional bookkeeping*, a phrase I intend to have carved somewhere eventually.

And on the fourth evening, the Horologists spent the hoard.

The city has a golden hour now, in its memory, that appears in no almanac. It came on like a tide of honey: every clock in Gravamen stopping together, politely, as if for a funeral — and then the light. Sunset ran backward. The undertakers came out onto their steps. The fog itself went up the terraces amber, and every sunbeam in the district — I felt them, all at once, the whole map of warm rectangles that a cat carries of any city — *ignited*, an hour of them, out of schedule, unbudgeted, free. Word had gone around the night-side in the mysterious total way it goes: rooflines and window-ledges filled with cats sitting up and down Gravamen like gargoyles' apprentices; Sootbeard on his corner three districts away reported afterward, formally, one (1) unscheduled sunrise, *received*. Merrow's lamplighters stood their ladders and let the lamps sleep through it. The old master sat his chair on the tower gallery with his guild around him and the

Court's two auditors standing witness at the parapet, gloves folded, metering the golden air with instruments of brass and, I will testify, not looking at the instruments overmuch.

He died eleven days later, out of schedule and in no one's debt, and the Court processed him — I have this from the Clerk — on a docket marked *paid in full, with sunrise*, and no one below the city found anything irregular in it at all.

The golden hour goes in this file for three reasons. Because the precedent is now law: *the Court will honor a debt of light against a debt of time, and will help compute it* — hold that sentence; the whole last chapter of this book stands on it. Because the auditors, who became first colleagues and then, in the way of auditors, something like friends, taught me over three days how collateral dockets are structured and — their eyes gleamed the way brass gleams — *mis-structured*. And because in the middle of the golden hour I looked away from the light, the only creature on that roofline looking away, and I watched the Mere.

The black glass did not take the gold. The whole city ambered, and the lake lay in the middle of it like a hole cut in the page — and around its rim, in the amber fog, shapes stood at intervals, unhurried, dry, *watching the light spend*, and I understood that we had just shown the patient thing under the water exactly how much this city still had left in its accounts worth taking.

An hour bought and spent for love, over a city, in the open. And sunk in the vaults below, behind a grille on grey ribbon: a hundred *years* of hours, banked in bronze.

The Mere and I, that golden evening, were doing the same arithmetic. Only one of us was hoping.

* * *

The Locksmiths' Fellowship holds secrets in escrow, and Box 9-Crown was due to open that midnight.

I must explain the trade, because the day-side thinks a locksmith sells locks. The Fellowship's true stock is *kept* secrets: locked boxes deposited with conditions — open on a date, on a death, on a marriage, on a bell — held in a hall with the best iron in the city

and a charter with better teeth than the iron. And the charter's terrible clause, the one that makes the whole trade honest, is this: a box whose condition has come due, and whose named claimant does not appear, is *unclaimed*, and an unclaimed secret is read aloud. On the steps. At midnight. In full. The Fellowship does not peek, does not edit, does not mercy. It is the reading-aloud that guarantees every other box in the hall: depositors trust the Locksmiths precisely because they have heard, from those steps, at some midnight of their lives, what the alternative to collecting your business costs.

Box 9-Crown was deposited forty years ago. Condition: *the death of the depositor, plus one season*. The depositor: E. Vane, of Thimblefield.

The season had turned that week.

I learned of it the way the whole night-side learned of it, which was all at once, from the Fellowship's crier posting the midnight docket at dusk — and by full dark the steps of the Locksmiths' hall held the strangest congregation of my season. Half the night-side wanted that box read: the Circuit's younger seats, hungry for anything of hers; Mistress Shear, near the front, wearing her correctness like frost; every broker of rumor in three districts; and — fog-smelling, gloved, at the edge of the lamplight where the eye slides — the Quiet Gentleman, attending in person, which the oldest heads on the steps said had not happened at a reading in living memory. The other half wanted it burned: Cardew, planted on the top step with her stick like a boundary-stone, on the simple grounds that whatever a dead witch locked away for forty years was locked away from *somebody*, and the somebody was likelier than not standing in this crowd. And at the rim of it all, out where the lamplight failed, the fog off the canals stood in its shapes and did not disperse, and I marked their spacing, and their patience, and counted the Mere among the interested parties.

Nine-Crown. She numbered it in the year of the seam, and she numbered it *nine*, and by then I no longer believed in this city's coincidences at all.

The Fellowship's law allows one interruption of a reading, and one only: a claimant. The box named its claimant in the deposit-deed, per the crier's docket, as *my heir, in law* — not by name, in the standard form — and Elspeth Vane died, the whole city knew, without kin,

without apprentice, intestate as weather. There was no heir in law. There was going to be a reading.

There was a cat on the steps.

I went up them at a quarter to midnight, past Shear's frost and Cardew's stick, and I sat down on the reading-stone itself in front of the Keeper of the Fellowship — a vast, slow, iron-colored woman with the manner of a door — and before the assembled night-side of Hollowmere I made my claim: heir in law to Elspeth Vane, of Needle Lane, called the Needle; her familiar of fifteen years; bearer of her unfinished magic, her collar, and her strand; mender of her wards; sewer of her shroud-seam, witnessed by the tide and Mother Cardew; presently investigating her murder.

The steps went up like the roosts in the seed audit. The Keeper looked down at me for a long iron moment. Then she pronounced what I had gambled the whole night on: that the claim was a real question, fit for a real court; that no reading may proceed while a real question stands; and that the Fellowship, whose charter predates the city's courts and defers to exactly one older jurisdiction, would refer the question of whether a cat can inherit to the only bench with standing over the estates of the dead.

The Hollow Court. A hearing. The box stayed — sealed, guarded, condition suspended — pending the ruling.

Two things happened in the crowd in the moment the gavel-word came down, and I was watching for both. Mistress Shear closed her eyes — relief or fury, I could not read which, and the not-reading kept her pinned to my board another chapter. And the Quiet Gentleman raised one gloved hand, at the edge of the lamplight, in the gesture of a man acknowledging a well-played trick at cards — then wrote something in a small book, and the writing of it reached me later that night, folded, fog-smelling, under my own door, in the only correspondence he has ever sent me. It said:

You have discovered the trade's one secret: possession is nothing; standing is everything. The hearing will be worth attending. I hold paper on several of the parties. — G.

And below that, in a hand suddenly smaller, as close to human as I ever saw him come:

She deposited it the week after the water. I brokered the box-fee. She paid it in tears — one vial, escrow-grade. I have never sold it.

Some accounts one keeps.

* * *

Home, late, the fog walking me the last three streets like a bailiff. And on the sill of her window, waiting for me, a vole.

Fresh. Whole. Laid straight along the sill-stone — not dropped, *placed*, wedged at the corner where the shutter meets the frame, exactly the way I had wedged the herring for the blind postmaster of the roosts, which is the way you leave food for a proud creature you do not intend to watch eat. The kill was clean, and old-fashioned, and close work. Some senior professional of the night-side, then, keeping accounts of his own.

I ate it on the sill in the fog, and I read it the plain way, the warm way: the city had begun, in its unbudgeted fashion, to keep its cat. Brindle carries my credit; Merrow chalks my mark; Sootbeard logs my crossings; and now somebody, wanting no receipt, had sent supper. A kindness from everyone and no one. I did not ask whose hand. Of all the exhibits in this file, it is the one I was glad to leave unattributed.

Tansy asleep in the exact center of the hearthrug; the board over the mantel crowded now, threads crossing threads, the whole city pinned and strung — and I sat up on the mantel among my exhibits and put the chapter in order, as she taught me, before sleep.

The Court will honor strange debts, strangely computed, if the paper is true: *proved, in gold, over Gravamen.*

The Court now owes me a hearing on the one question — can a cat inherit? — whose answer unlocks everything at once: the box and its forty-year secret; the estate; the standing to petition, as her heir, against dockets a stranger cannot touch. A bell's docket, say.

And in a vault under the city, behind grey ribbon: her confession — I was as sure of it as I have been sure of anything since the kettle — her own account of the water, the working, and the eight lights I watched go out at the corner of a dream. Deposited the week after the seam, sealed against the day of her death plus one season, addressed to an heir she would not name and kept count toward for forty years. *Nine is the number I owe.*

She knew the bill would come due. She banked the truth against it, and paid the fee in tears, and spent the rest of her life assembling — stray by stray, nine attempts, one signature — somebody to read it.

Nine is the number I owe. I know where I first heard that sentence: the chart-table, the lamplight, her voice above the needle, amused — *that winter I tried eight strays* — and me small and certain in the middle of her half-sewn work. That night, before sleep, I reached for the Day itself, the way I had reached for it all season — to sit in the warm of it a minute, under the lamp, beside the voice.

It is not there. The Toll took it at the flats, and I had felt it go, and that night on the mantel I finally went to look at what the going means. It means the fact is still mine — eight strays, nine owed; her voice said so; my own file says so — and the room the fact was kept in is gone. No lamp. No table. No voice over the needle. My own handwriting, telling me there was a voice. I sat with the difference a long time, up among the exhibits, with the whole case strung and pinned within reach and the one place I wanted to go in it nowhere at all.

The case was all still there. The warm was not.

The hearing was set for the dark of the moon. Before it, one more parcel of her estate was to find me — the last, the strangest, thirty years late and insistent on a signature.

But that is the next chapter, and I have been fifteen years learning not to pull a thread before its turn.

Chapter 11

The Testimony and the Last Parcel

The night-post of Hollowmere is punctual on a geologic scale, and it chose that week to deliver.

The postman came up Needle Lane at the hour between the last lamp and the first gull, in a coat of a cut not seen since before the bell was pawned, with a parcel lashed in oiled string and a manner that suggested the intervening thirty years were a rumor he had declined to countersign. The parcel was addressed to *Elspeth Vane, Needle Lane, Thimblefield* — in her own hand. Mailed by her, thirty years ago, to her future self. Postage due.

He would not leave it. He would not discuss it. He required, he said, consulting a delivery-book bound in what I earnestly hope was leather, *a signature* — the addressee's, or, the addressee being deceased (he pronounced it like a foreign currency), that of her successor in law; and there being, at the present hour, no adjudicated successor in law, he would return — he consulted the book again — *at the same hour, following the determination of the question*, and he walked back down the lane into the fog with the parcel under his arm and thirty more years of patience visibly available to him.

So now two locked things in this city were waiting on one question, and the question had a date at the dark of the moon, and I spent the intervening nights doing what any respectable litigant does: assembling witnesses and being unable to sleep.

* * *

The Hollow Court does not, as a rule, sit on the affairs of the living. The question of whether a cat can inherit turned out to be, on the Clerk's own reading of his own charter — and I have never seen a man happier in a finding — neither an affair of the living nor of the dead, but of an *estate*, and estates are the Court's native soil, and so it came to pass that the corridor of shelves grew a courtroom the way the desk had grown a cat-sized chair: quietly, overnight, without anyone admitting to the carpentry.

I will give the hearing as the file requires: parties, testimony, exhibits, ruling. I was not calm. The file does not care.

In the matter of the estate of E. Vane (intestate): on the question of succession.

The Clerk presided — there is, it emerges, a higher bench below him, and it emerges further that the higher bench owes the Clerk four centuries of deferred leave and defers to him in all matters he cares to keep, and he had cared to keep this one. His enthusiasm was total and totally suppressed, expressed exclusively through the turning-up of the lamp and the presence, on the bench, of *two* inkwells.

For the claim: myself. Heir-presumptive; cat.

Against: the Circuit's advocate — a dry young seat from Gravamen with a conscience visibly too good for her brief, instructed to secure the estate's workings "for the public safety" — and, joined to her side by motion, with her own advocate and her frost worn like court dress: Mistress Shear, rival claimant, petitioning that the estate's technical effects (the workbooks, the sampler, the stitching itself, so far as a stitch can be deviled into property) pass to "the qualified," meaning the seat-hungry, meaning her.

The Gentleman attended. He sat at the back with the fog folded around his ankles and held, I do not doubt, paper on every party present, including the bench, excluding me. The Court of Whiskers filed an amicus brief. It was a dead moth of unusual quality, presented by a deputation of three seniors who sat through the proceedings on the gallery rail with their tails wrapped, and the Clerk entered it into evidence without a flicker, as *amicus curiae*, one (1), *lepidopteral* — which is Court for a friend of the court, in moth form — and I watched the Circuit's advocate decide not to object and grow, in my

estimation, considerably.

The testimony for my claim, in the order it was given, because the order broke me a little and the reader may as well be broken in order:

Mother Cardew, on the shroud-seam: that at the tide-turn, before the assembled guilds, the deceased's own burial stitch was completed *in the deceased's own hand* by the claimant; that in sixty years of Circuit service she has known the hand of every stitcher in this city, and that what closed that shroud was not an imitation of Elspeth Vane's hand but its *continuation*; and that she had tied her own debt into the claimant's thread on the quay, in public, "because one does not tie debts into property. One ties them into *persons*."

Merrow, with the shift-book under her arm, on the hall's ward: mended by the claimant, unasked, in front of the guild; holding to this night. She chalked the hall's tally-mark on the Court's own floor to show what the mark meant, and did not apologize to anyone, and the Clerk had the mark entered into evidence *in situ*, which I believe means the Hollow Court now bears, somewhere in its corridor, one stroke of a lamplighter's chalk that may not lawfully be washed.

Brindle, on trade: that the Exchange had dealt with the claimant across a season as a principal, not as a curiosity; that he pays, collects, redeems, and holds credit; and that "the Exchange has fenced for four hundred years, m'lud, and we have never once extended an account to *property*."

And then the Circuit's advocate, doing her instructed duty, called her joined party to establish the counter-claim — *the qualified hand* — and Mistress Shear took the stand, and the hearing became, for one hour, the other thing. The thing I had been building toward since a draped chair in the Circuit's long room.

Because I had standing to cross-examine. And I had spent three days with two auditors learning what a docket can be made to ask.

I did not ask her about the murder. Ask a frightened witch about a murder and you get a wall; her advocate was primed for the wall; the wall was rehearsed. I asked her instead — mildly, from the claimant's little table, with the Court's own exhibit-request already granted and the Fellowship's iron box-men carrying it in — about *qualification*. She had petitioned on the strength of her hand. Very well: here, entered as exhibit, was a hand's length of warding in the

Vane stitch, mirror-handed — the sample, her sample, surrendered under subpoena from the locked box in her workroom, the box she swore was never unlocked. Would the qualified candidate, before the bench, demonstrate the stitch she proposed to inherit?

She looked at the sample a long moment. Frost, at close range, is thinner than it looks from the gallery.

She tried. I will give her that much forever: she took the needle, before the Hollow Court and the Circuit's advocate and three senior cats and the fog-ankled Gentleman, and she tried the stitch, and her good journeyman hands produced good journeyman work, forward-handed, correct, and *nothing like it* — and she knew it before the thread was drawn, and something in her that ambition had been holding upright for twenty years sat down at last, in front of everyone.

She did not speak. That is the whole of it, and it was the loudest thing said at the hearing. She looked at the drawn thread a long moment, and laid the needle down square on the exhibit-cloth, the way you lay down something you have decided not to carry any further, and went back to her place and sat, upright, correct, hands folded — and when the bench asked whether the petitioner wished to address her demonstration, her advocate rose, looked once at her face, and withdrew the claim entire. She looked at me then, the only time she ever did. There was nothing in the look I could file. There did not need to be. The Court, which knows testimony when it hears it, let the silence stand unabridged.

The Clerk waited a decent interval, then took up the exhibit-sample himself, ran it through his fingers the way he runs thread, and put on the record, drily, the finding that mattered to my other case, the one no bench had convened:

“The Court notes for its own files that the work in this exhibit is of a craft this bench has encountered *elsewhere*, in matters irregular; that the documents before this bench date her acquisition of it to a period well within her adult practice; and that the craft itself, on the evidence of this Court's oldest colleagues—” a granite salute from the gallery; Sootbeard had insisted on attending; the floor had been reinforced by order, “—has been in continuous exercise in this city for not less than forty years. The witness would have been an apprentice of nine at its first attestation. The bench observes, for whatever bench may someday need the observation, that *she did not*

make this. She merely wanted it. Wanting is not yet a filing category.”

Eliminated. The third suspect, cleared of the murder by the same arithmetic that convicted her of the wanting, in open court, on the record. And the Gentleman, at the back — my second suspect, my elegant impossibility — rose at the finding, bowed to the bench with the particular completeness of a creditor closing a file, and left, and folded on the bench where he had sat was his own last exhibit, tendered unasked: the brokerage-trail of the circular, entire — the fog-paper, the knot-signed commission, the account settled in wound grey thread — every document of the technique’s marketing, which is to say every document proving that the hand behind it was a client even he had never seen, and that the one being in Hollowmere who profits on every open account had been paid, for the first time in his existence, in the one currency that only ends. One smaller paper rode in the trail, and it closed a question this file had carried since a wet night in the second chapter. A carrier’s counterfoil: one cart, Needle Lane to the Wickhouse, the cargo entered as *street-thread, harvested, spooled* — the lane’s own stitching, riding heavy toward the water and coming home light. And behind that cart, in no hurry, the one walker the Grey Boss could never book: the house walks behind its blind commissions — blind for the client is not blind for the house — and the gentleman going nowhere in particular, the whole way down the lane, had been the house, attending its paper. He would not spend lives. He *banks*. It was never him, and he had known from the first fog-smelling card that I would need to prove it rather than believe it, and he had waited, with a broker’s patience, for the hearing where the proof would fetch its best price.

The price, his note said — there was a note; there is always a note — was this: *One knot, little rival, of my choosing, at a time of my choosing. You now owe the house. — G.*

I read it, and I looked at the empty bench-end where the fog was still unfolding, and I paid it the way you pay him, which is by continuing to exist with the debt attached. The Court of Whiskers’ deputation watched me fold the paper into my shadow and said nothing with enormous volume.

Through the whole of the hearing the deputation had kept the gallery rail, and through the whole of it I had been reading the senior grey who led it — the gait as he shifted on the rail, the count and

care of an old tom's settle — the way I read evidence. I hated the reading, and I did not stop.

And one more name came off my board that day, by the dullest instrument in this file: a ledger. The deputation on the gallery rail was led by a senior grey — a tom of exactly the wrong vintage, adult when the seam was sewn; I had logged him the week of the cat-shaped finding and hated the logging, and when I had asked after his whereabouts at the neap, the answer had come back *nowhere that paper reaches*, which cleared nothing. So I had petitioned the Whiskers for his chronicle, and the Whiskers, who minute everything and forgive nothing, sent it to the hearing under seal: forty years of session-rolls, his lives reconciled to the entry — one spent on the plague-roofs, one at the weir, both minuted, both mourned in session, seven standing. A creature who had paid eight lives into a seam would be walking his last; the senior grey was seven deep, witnessed at every loss, and his *nowhere*, the rolls showed, was the Whiskers' own closed sessions, which paper does not reach because the Whiskers burn their drafts. He was old, and grey, and of the year, and that is all he ever was.

And then the ruling. The Clerk read it himself, from a page he had — I could see it from the claimant's table — written out fair twice:

In the matter of the estate of E. Vane: it is the finding of this Court that a familiar in surviving receipt of his witch's unfinished working is not the estate's property but its residuary legatee; that the bond of a familiar, being a thread tied by the decedent herself and severed by no instrument this Court recognizes, constitutes designation in her own hand; and that the claimant — Ashcat, of Needle Lane, called the Needle's heir — is so adjudged, with all rights, workings, debts, and standings of the estate, to hold and to answer for. The Court further notes that it has now, at last, filed something under 'nine' without irregularity, and found the experience restful. Next matter.

The stamp came down. Paw print. Nobody remarked on it. The gallery rail purred — three seniors, formally, in unison, which is a decoration I will put against any medal this city mints — and Mother Cardew looked at the ceiling of the corridor of shelves and said, to a woman forty years and one season dead, "There. *Now* scold me," and had to sit down.

* * *

Box 9-Crown was opened to me that same night, in the Fellowship's iron reading-room, alone, as the deed provided: *my heir, in law, and none other present.*

I am not going to transcribe her confession. I have thought about it the whole length of this book, and the answer does not change: the reading was provided to her heir and none other present, and the deed's conditions bind me still, and the reader will receive what the case requires and not one word more. The case requires this much:

That it was written the week after the water, in her hand at its youngest and worst, blotted — she who never blotted — and that it set down, plainly, as an account against herself, everything my dreams had shown me at the tactful corner: the seam; the price of its anchor; that the price was paid in lives, *and the lives were not mine.* That the one who paid kept a single life and walked into the fog and would not be found, and that she did not follow, “because what I owed could not be paid by finding him, and what he needed could not be survived by me.” That thread which has become stitch is not thread any more — her own sentence, the sentence I have carried since like a second collar — *I could not give them back, and I could not wind him new ones: winding wants an unspent spool, and his is stitch to the heart. So I will make nine new ones, and give those.*

There was one thing more in the box, flat under the confession at the iron bottom: a receipt, forty years old, for one (1) candle, beeswax, escrow-grade, sold out of the Gentleman's house the week after the water. She would not have the rich man's smell in her house; I built the first chapter of this file on that. But the same week she banked her confession she bought one fine candle, and kept it forty years — held, like everything else in that box, against the settlement she never stopped expecting to make. The good light you keep against a guest you owe.

Nine pockets. Nine lives. Fifteen years of evenings with her needle in my shadow while I slept on her work and took it for petting. The heir reports that he sat in an iron room under the city with his witch's forty-year-old handwriting between his paws and understood at last that he is not her cat so much as her *restitution* — a debt paid forward to the species, one life over par, against an account

that could never be settled at the source.

And the confession's last line, which I will give entire, because it is the only will she ever left and I am its executor:

If he comes to collect — and he is owed; whatever he has become, write it at the head of every page, HE IS OWED — then let my heir pay what I could not. I do not know if that is mercy or justice. Whichever is dearer. She always knew the difference, and I never did.

She wrote *she*. Forty years before me. I have decided — executor's discretion — that she was allowed to hope her ninth would be a she, and that I am allowed to have read it anyway.

* * *

I walked home from the iron room over the roofs, the long way, and I will set this part down plainly or not at all.

She spent him. Eight lives, at her own needle, out of a creature who stood to her while it was done — stood, the way a familiar stands, the way I have stood to her over lesser work a thousand evenings, certain past thought that the needle would never turn. Then she came off the water alone, and let him walk into the fog with the one life she had left him, and did not follow. Forty years she wrote *he is owed* at the head of every page. Writing a debt at the head of every page is not paying it.

And my whole life was lived inside her amends. The fire, the window, the kettle at dusk — fifteen years on the warm side of an account, while the creature the account was owed to sat out on the sea-wall and watched the lamp burn. She knew he was there. Knowing was her trade. She put the kettle on anyway, every evening, and never once told me what I was standing in.

I came down to Needle Lane and could not go in. I sat on the step of a dead woman's house until the fog came up, and then I was at the doorpost with my claws, and it was not sharpening.

In the chest-ledger, that night, I wrote nothing. I tried. I could not put her name at the head of a page, because under her name the next line was waiting, and I could not write them together — the woman at the window and the woman on the water. The small honest hand does not have a sentence that holds both. The page is blank. It is still blank.

The kettle sat cold on its stone inside, and nobody was expecting me anywhere, and that night, for the first time since the parlor, I was glad of it.

* * *

The postman returned at the hour between the last lamp and the first gull, consulted his book, accepted my signature — a paw print, pressed beside her name; the Court had certified the mark that afternoon with what I can only call institutional glee — collected thirty years' postage due (Brindle advanced it against the estate; the sum had compounded into something a bargeman would respect), and left me the parcel.

Inside: a spool of ordinary thread.

Her first. I knew it before the wrapping was off — the case knew it; Box 9-Crown was 9; the parcel was mailed thirty years back but the spool was older, forty at least, wound by hands still learning, the way beginners keep their first anything: too carefully. Ordinary grey linen thread, slightly waxed, the kind you hem a curtain with. No working in it at all. That was the point of it, I would understand within the hour; it was the point of everything she ever kept.

And beneath the spool, a note, folded small, sealed with a pressed geranium petal gone to brown paper. On the outside, her hand — the late hand now, the hand I knew, so she had opened her own parcel to her future self at some point, and added to it, and sent it on again — the parcel mailed thirty years ago, the spool ten years older than the mailing, the note newer than both — and there is a whole grief in that image I have not finished having:

For after. You will know when after is.

It is a measure of what this season has done to me that I did not open it. She had built the case like a garment, seam by seam, each thing in its turn, and the note said *after*, and after had not come. I put it in the ninth pocket — the deepest, the one over the heart-shadow — and I took up the spool, because the spool's turn *had* come, and its turn was the lesson.

The estate of a witch, the Clerk's ruling ran, passes "to hold and to answer for," and holding it has requirements. A dead witch's

wards want maintaining. Her heir must stitch — not mend, as I had mended, by imitation and grief, but *stitch*: begin, work, and tie off, on his own hand, from his own spool. And I held one torn thing that was hers and mine and wanted no witness: the pockets of my shadow. Two of them torn — the Toll's fee has a place it comes from; I had felt each one go, at the parlor, at the flats, like a seam in a coat you are wearing when it parts.

So on the night after the hearing I sat on the workroom floor in the moon's full lamp, my shadow thrown clean on her boards, the first spool beside me, and I stitched.

Cardew had offered supervision. I had declined, and she had looked at me the way she looks at weather and gone home. This was between me and the shadow. I threaded the bone needle the way the shroud had taught me. I found the torn mouth of the first pocket — you can touch your own shadow, if it is moonlight and the shadow has been sewn in before; it takes the pale strength and it feels, I will report exactly once, like touching the underside of your own name — and I began, and my paws, unwatched, unhurried, with no ward to match and no pattern to follow, ran the stitches *mirror-wise*. Right to left. Every stitch. Not error; *grain*. The thread lay down that way like fur lies down, and fought the other way, and I stopped, halfway along the torn pocket, in the cold moonlight, and looked at my own work.

Her stitch. Reversed. Perfect. *Faster than any needle honestly goes* — because a familiar's paws do not learn the stitch from the needle's side. They learn it from the lap. Fifteen years on the near side of the work, watching from in front, every evening, the needle coming *toward* me — of course it is mirrored. It could be nothing else. And I understood, sitting halfway along my own shadow with the needle in my teeth, the thing Shear's silence had sat down under in open court: it is not a technique. It is a *life*. It is the shape left in a body by years of lying against someone else's work.

Nobody taught the murderer her stitch.

Nobody needed to. Elspeth taught exactly nobody, and it did not matter, because the stitch teaches itself to anything that loves the stitcher from close enough, for long enough — and there had been, for years, before me, on the near side of the work, at the corner of every tactful dream, a first learner. A grey one. Spent, unpaid, owed,

missing — *he is owed, write it at the head of every page* — one life kept, forty years of half-seconds, a thread in her key mended at the neap, and a knot-hand that death's clerk and debt's gentleman both file under *not one of ours*.

And I sat there in the moonlight with my needle in my own shadow, and the whole book I have been writing you turned over at once, like the tide, and re-read itself.

You fight like a housecat. — I was one. — Were. A paw on my scruff, sure as her hands, hauling me from the watch. *Watch the paws, not the claws* — the lesson you give a young cat you cannot afford to see die, from the one creature in the city who knew precisely what my deaths cost, because he was paying for them. Every refusal, every stamp, every walk up the long stairs, paid for by close work, old-fashioned, fond.

I knew your witch to look at. Everyone did.

True. Every word he ever said to me was true. That is what the truth is for, if you are careful with it for forty years: it is for wearing, the way a coat on a hook is person-shaped, the way a shape in a parlor doorway wore a room of threads and looked at a small ruined cat on the threshold and *decided he was not an interruption* — decided, I now knew, with the only tenderness left in it, that whatever else was to be unpicked in that house, the ninth stray would not be.

I wrote the name in the ledger of my chest, at the head of the page, under the sentence she had ordered written there.

He is owed. — Bodkin.

Then I finished the pocket. Both pockets. Mirror-handed, in her first thread, to the end of the seam and the tying-off, because the estate passes *to hold and to answer for*, and I was, from that night, entirely certain which of the two I intended to do, and entirely wrong about it, and the being who could have told me so was out at the black water's edge, at the anchor of the world's most expensive seam, unpicking.

Chapter 12

The Ninth Bell

The last Remembered Day came to me that same night, unhunted, in her chair.

I had never slept in the chair. The chair was not mine to fill; that had been a rule of the new world, and I had kept it through everything. But I came up from the workroom with my shadow newly whole and the name written at the head of the page, and the house was doing a thing it had not done since the kettle: it was *waiting* — and the chair stood in the moon's lamp with her shape still in the cushions, and I understood, in the way one understands the last turn of a route, that the rule had expired. That this was the door the dreams had been walking me toward all season, and it would only open from inside her chair, and it would only open once.

I got up into it. I put my chin where her hand used to fall.

And it was morning. *That* morning.

I will set it down plainly. It has no fog in it, no water, none of the tactful corners of the other dreams — because it is not her memory of a great working, guarded even in death. It is only her last ordinary day, kept in the cushions of a chair, and the pale strength paid it out to me whole, at par, one final draw against an account that closed at dusk.

Grey early light. The kettle on for her own tea — the first kettle, the innocent one. She moves slowly; I had not seen it in the living days and I saw it now, the whole dream saw it: she is *spent*. Weeks of it. Wards failing all over her district faster than they should — the alarm-threads she keeps on forty years of workings tugging at

her one after another, here a hem gone at the fish market, there a binding loose at the tannery, each one an evening's mending, each mending drawing down a purse that does not refill at her age — and she knows. I watched her know. She stands at the workroom wall with her tea going cold, reading her own cut city the way I would later read her cut walls, and she says, to the wall, in the flat voice she kept for arithmetic that would not come out otherwise:

“Ward by ward. You are emptying me first, my grey one. That is craftsmanlike.”

She does not weep, and she does not send for the Circuit, and now I know why on both counts: the confession in the iron box. *He is owed*. You do not call the constables on your own creditor. You settle, or you are collected, and she had spent forty years failing to invent a settlement, and so she did the only other thing she has ever done with a debt whose day has come. She put her books in order.

I watched her do it. It takes the whole dream, and it is the most terrible housekeeping ever performed, because none of it is for her. The workroom tidied — for whoever must read the room after. Her second-best thimble set square on the workbox — for the trade it would someday buy. The beeswax candle — the good one, bought forty years ago and never yet burned — out of its drawer and stood in its holder in the parlor, unlit, where a guest would see it. The red kerchief, washed at the basin, wrung, and folded on the sewing table — not put away; *folded, on the table, where a cat coming over the sill could not miss it*. She had washed it that morning. I had carried that fact since the prologue of this book like a pebble in the pad, and here was its whole weight: she folded her collar for me before noon, on the day she died at dusk, because she did not intend to be wearing it when the collecting came, and she did not intend it to go to the tide with her either.

Last of all, the sunbeam. Late morning, the good one, the March-through-October beam that crosses the work-table at eleven, and I am asleep in the middle of her chart-papers in it, because I was; I remember the day now from both sides, hers and mine, and from my side it was nothing, it was any day, it was a nap. From her side: she sets down her pen, and looks at me a long time, doing what I now recognize as the other ledger, the margin one. Then she crosses the room and *picks me up* — lifts me off her work the way you

lift someone who might wake, one hand under, one hand over, the single liberty I permitted in this world and permitted to her alone — and she carries me, the whole slow length of the workroom, to the hearthrug, and puts me down in the poorer, warmer light, and stands over me with her emptied hands, and says:

“There. Mind the house, Ash. I am going to see about the lamps.”

That is all. That is the whole bequest of the last Remembered Day: she carried me off her unfinished work and set me down by the fire, and went out on her own feet to be exhausted a final ward further, and the dream ends not at the parlor — it spares us both the parlor — but at the door, with her hand on the latch and her back to me and the evening coming up the lane to meet her, and I woke in her chair at the greyest hour with my face wet in the way of cats, which is invisibly, and no one will ever prove otherwise.

And I knew that *after* had come.

The note came out of the ninth pocket smelling of geranium and forty years. Her late hand, small, unblotted, entirely herself:

If you are reading this, then you have done everything in the correct order, which means you are mine, which means I am past scolding you and it has all become your business after all. Very well. Three items, and mind the sequence, you know how I am about sequence.

The bell wants ringing. The Court has held the city's hour a hundred years and the Court, of all of them, keeps honest books — make the books say so. Nothing anchors without a measure, and I had the ninth bell the first time. You will need it.

Spend nothing you cannot re-sew. I mean this. Your lives are not a purse, whatever the arrangement downstairs has taught you. They are the only thing I ever made without owing.

And when you meet my first — for you will; sequence, Ash; you were always the ninth of nine — tell him what he is owed. I could not walk into the fog to say it, and I will not say it through you. You have read my books. You know the words.

The kettle is not your fault. Whatever happens, whatever you saw: the kettle is not your fault. I know you took it off the fire. I know it took three tries.

— E.

I sat in her chair while the grey came up the windows, and then

I did what she said, in sequence, because I know how she is about sequence.

I went and made the books say so.

* * *

The redemption of the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere took four days, one cat, two auditors, a clerk, and no miracles at all, which is why it worked.

I petitioned as the Needle's heir. The bell had been signed out once in a century — one night, forty years ago, on the Circuit's surety, *for the great sewing* — and a surety, my grey-gloved colleagues confirmed, gleaming, confers standing on the surety's successors in the matter of the collateral. I had inherited, along with a house and a strand and nine pockets, the right to be heard on the docket of a pawned bell.

And the docket, once a profession finally located its error, was glorious. The auditors metered the vault itself — the first audit of the Court's own holdings, they believed, since the pawn was struck — and the finding ran thus: the bell had been taken as *dead* collateral, a thing of bronze, valued at its metal against a plague-season's unpaid Tolls. But the bell was never dead stock. The bell held the ninth hour — every night's unrun hour pooling into it for a hundred years, unclaimed, unspent, *accruing* — and the Court's own charter, the Clerk read aloud with two inkwells going, requires accrual on held assets to be credited against the securing debt. A century of banked hours, at the Court's own posted rate for time — the rate it charges the Horologists; there was rich justice in that — against one plague-season of Tolls.

The debt had been paid off, by the bell itself, sometime in the reign before last. Everything since was overage. The city of Hollowmere, the finding concluded, did not owe the Hollow Court. The Hollow Court owed the city *an hour a night for a hundred years*, and the instrument of repayment was hanging in its own evidence vault, and the precedent for repaying a debt of time in light — *proved, in gold, over Gravamen* — was already on the books, because we had put it there.

The Clerk wrote out the finding fair, twice, and stamped it — with feeling, I would testify; the paw print came down like a bell itself — and rose from his desk, and took his lamp, and personally led the way down the cross-aisle to the grille on its grey ribbon.

“I have processed irregularity all my death,” he said, unlocking it. “Permit me, once, to originate some.”

They rang it that night.

Not hoisted — there was no time and no tower; the seam, my whole pelt could feel by then, was down to its last threads at the anchor; the fog stood in the streets at noon; the Drowned walked the Mereside terraces in numbers the day-side could no longer unsee. The Court rang it *where it hung*, in the vault under everything, at the stroke where the ninth hour of the night had fallen silent a century ago — the Clerk’s own hand on the rope, two auditors metering, one cat present as petitioner of record —

and the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere spoke for the first time in a hundred years, down under the city, up through the stones, out through every cellar and hearthstone and bone of the town: *nine*.

I was already running for the water when the first stroke caught me. The city was behind me doing the thing I will spend the epilogue describing, and ahead of me, out past the sea-wall, at the far low line of the ebb, the black flats lay shining under the fog like a spilled mirror, and out on them, small at the anchor of the world, something person-shaped stood wearing the last of my witch’s greatest seam, unpicking by the light it had paid half a century of half-seconds to reach.

It was the neap. Of course it was the neap. The mender comes at the neap.

* * *

Tansy was at the sea-wall stair, planted across my path, orange and entirely certain. “I am coming. I am fierce. I can bite fog.” “Mind the house, Tansy,” I said, and she turned and ran for Needle Lane as if the house were a thing that could get away.

I went out over the flats alone, on the ninth bell’s ninth stroke, and the fog opened me a lane the whole way, which I understood was not courtesy. The Mere wanted witnesses.

The Unpicked stood at the anchor-stitch as it had stood in her parlor: unhurried, absorbed, wearing its woven habit of stolen threads — her wards, her walls, forty years of her work wound about an absence — and its hands, which I could see now as I could not in the parlor, because now I knew what I was looking at, moved on the great seam *mirror-wise*, right to left, lifting her stitches whole, in her order, run backward, each one releasing into the black water below with a sound like a word unsaid. So that was the lamps, the night she died: he had lit the lane mirror-order because the order is the stitch, and a round run backward is an unpicking — her ward was off the lane before he ever reached the gate. The anchor was most of the way out. Under the flats, under the glass, all the way down, the patient one lay against the underside of the world with its whole weight, no longer hoping. *Certain*.

I did not fight it. I want the record to be exact, because everything in this book has been walking to this stone: I came onto the last stretch of mirror-flat, and I sat down on the wet shining black in front of the person-shaped absence in its coat of my inheritance, in easy reach of the hands that had murdered my witch and defeated me at my own hearth, and I said what her books had taught me to say, in the words she had trusted me to find.

“The account was never closed on her side either. Not for one evening of forty years. The window was never only for me.”

The hands stopped.

The flats were very quiet. The fog stood in its ring. Down under the glass, something vast recalculated.

“She wrote it,” I said. “Forty years ago, the week after the water, in a box with your number on it. *He is owed — write it at the head of every page*. I have read every page. It is at the head of every page. And I am her heir, in law, adjudicated, to hold and to answer for — and I have come to answer for it. Not to the lake.” I looked up at where a face was not. “To you. Bodkin.”

And the Unpicked came apart.

Not as a defeat. As an *undressing*. The woven habit unwound itself from the top down, thread releasing thread, her wards sighing off it into slack coils on the shining black — the garment he had worn to do the work of a creditor, taken off, at last, because he had been called by name to a settlement, and you attend a settlement as

yourself — and when it was done, standing on the flats in the ring of fog, on the last thread-bare stitches of the anchor, was a grey tom. Old. Big-boned under a coat that had seen forty years of weather. One eye. Half of one ear. The stillness of a creature that has spent a long time being exactly as visible as it chooses.

“You fight like a housecat,” he said. The voice was the alley voice, unchanged, and it broke something in me that the parlor had not managed.

“I was one.”

“Were,” he agreed. And then, for the first time in our acquaintance, he said something that was not load-bearing, and it came out of him like the anchor coming out of the seam: “You were the only thing in that house I could not unpick. Fifteen years I watched her wind you. Nine lives, kit. Nine, on her own needle, out of her own evenings — I sat on the sea-wall and *watched the lamp burn* while she sewed you a fortune, and I told the water: you see. You see what she has. She could always make more. She only ever could not make *mine* back.”

“She could not make yours back,” I said. “That is in the box too, in her own hand, blotted. *Thread that has become stitch is not thread any more*. It is the first law of her whole craft and you know it better than I do; you have been unpicking her stitches all season and not one of them has come off the seam as a life. They come off as *slack*.” I put my paw on the coils of released warding lying dead on the black mirror between us. “Look at it. This is what the lake has been paying you in promises. Spent is spent, Bodkin. Open the seam to the bottom and your eight lives do not come out — nothing comes out but the thing that told you they would. It found someone with a grievance and it fed the grievance a refund that does not exist. It lied to you the way you have been not-lying to me: precisely, and to purpose.”

“To purpose,” he agreed. “Everything to purpose. All of it mine, and none of it small. Put it all on the bill.”

I put it on the bill. And then I did what a settlement requires, because I am her heir and her books are exact on the point: before anything is paid, the account is stated entire, aloud, by the party holding the pen. So I stated it.

“Elsbeth Vane, stitcher of Hollowmere, unpicked in her own parlor at dusk. Before her, the two stitchers this city agreed to forget: the

lady of the Tatterstage, who kept her seam under the greasepaint, and the second, whose file the Circuit closed with nobody looking. They were the only hands left in Hollowmere that could have re-anchored the seam once it opened, and you removed them decades ahead of the need, the way a professional removes the locks before the robbery." He did not correct me. "The lamplighters' hall, emptied on the true word that there was work elsewhere, from the one voice that knew where elsewhere was. The roosts, drawn down over years, coat by coat, until missing looked like weather. Fenn, who walked into the fog while his lamp was still burning. The frame, hung on a hungry living neck so the Circuit would spend its season watching the living. The wisps on the lamplighters' round, taught the route and the taste of it. And under the whole of it, wound small and banked deep, forty years of stolen half-seconds off the stock of every soul in the city. That is the account."

He did not flinch, and he did not dispute the total. I crossed a charge off my own page besides, one Merrow had laid on me at the hall door: the teacher of the wisps' route, found.

"There is a line missing," I said. "The parlor. That first night was my death too, and the Court did not post the appointment. The line for the posting hand stands blank."

"It stands blank because the hand was mine." The one eye did not move off me. "I posted it myself, kit — the gentlest slot on the whole ledger. You were going to spend that life on the wraith whatever any soul did. All there was left to choose was the desk you woke at, and I chose it."

"I took the long way home."

"And the eleven minutes bought you nothing. The work was done between the boiling and the scream. Do the sum you have been refusing."

"And the missing?" It came out of him fast, and I heard it for what it was: the last plank of a bridge he had been standing on for years. "The coats. The roosts. The hall — the hall walked out on its own feet; every soul in it had heard there was work elsewhere that night, and I told them where elsewhere was. I fed it *down-payments*, kit — its terms, not mine — but they are held, not spent; they went down whole; I know held from spent, I have been both." The one eye was terrible. "It gives them back when the seam opens. That is the

contract.”

“The contract,” I said, “is void for fraud on the consideration. The lake cannot pay you the eight; the eight are the seam. Your refund was always going to be the city, Bodkin. Everyone’s. That is all it had to sell, against the one thing it had spent forty years making sure you could never have. And you have known it all season, because you have carried the proof in your own teeth — every stitch you lifted, coming off the seam as slack. I said it aloud once, on a sea-wall, to what I thought was fog. You heard it, and you have never once looked at it, because grief is the one auditor that refuses its own evidence.” I stood up on the black glass. “She knew. It is the last thing in the box. She could not give you your lives back, and she could not survive giving you the rest of hers, and so she did what she did with every debt she could not pay at the source. She paid it forward. Nine lives, made new, given to your kind — *whichever is dearer, mercy or justice* — and then she sat in her chair at the end of an emptied day and heard your paws on the sill, and—”

“*Don’t*,” said Bodkin.

“—and put the kettle on,” I said. “For two.”

The fog ring stood. The bell’s ninth stroke was long gone but the bronze of it was still in the stones, in the water, in the pads of my feet. And the oldest professional in Hollowmere, the fond ghost of my whole season, the murderer of Elspeth Vane, sat down on the mirror-flats in front of me the way Shear had sat down inside her own life, and said, in the alley voice, very evenly, the way you report a position:

“She said, ‘You’ll take tea, then.’ Forty years, and that is what she said. And I stood in her parlor with the night’s work in my hands and I could not tell if it was surrender or welcome, and I have done the one thing since that I have never done in this city.” The eye closed. “I did not look. Four seconds, kit. Her own rule. I did not spend four seconds looking, because if it was welcome, I could not have collected, and I had made the water a promise that could not survive her pouring the tea.”

“It was both,” I said. “It was her hand. You knew her hand. It was always both.”

“It was always both,” said Bodkin, and the last plank went out from under him, and he was only old, and grey, and one life deep,

sitting on the black glass at the anchor of everything, mourning the woman he had murdered, forty years too late and one evening too early, with her heir and her kerchief three feet away and the drowned certainty of the Mere coming up under all of us like a page turning.

Because it came, then. Of course it came. It had heard the settlement it could not survive.

* * *

The water did not rise; the *flats* rose, the whole mirror flexing upward like the lid of an eye, and the ring of fog fell in on us from every side at once, and the Drowned came out of it arriving — all of them, a city's century of them, dry-footed on the buckling glass — and under the failing anchor the patient one put its whole weight on the last threads, no longer patient, and the seam began, stitch by stitch down its forty-year length, to *sing* — the sound her wards made dying in the parlor, scaled to a lake.

"It needs an anchor," I said. "Now. A new one." I was already pulling the pale strength up through me, all of it, and the first spool out of my shadow, and I knew the price of an anchor; I had watched it paid at the corner of a dream — and I had seven lives banked and a mirror-hand and her thread, and I stood on the flats and offered it, out loud, formally, the way the estate answers: "Take mine. Seven. It held on eight; it will hold on seven; I will argue the difference with the lake personally—"

"Spent is spent," said Bodkin.

He said it quietly, and he was standing when he said it, and everything unhurried had gone out of him except the last thing, the craftsman's thing, the thing that had pulled me out of the watch's path and taught me the paws and mended my thread eleven times between audits.

"Your own law, kit. You just taught it to me on this very stone; do me the courtesy of losing an argument on it. An anchor wants a life that is *finished paying*. Yours are new-made and owed forward — she made them without owing and you will not owe them to this." He looked at the water. "Mine has been finished for forty years. I kept it back out of spite, and spite is paid off. And—" the one eye

came around to me, and it had in it, at the end, the whole voice of the alley, dry, fond, appalling, “—I have an appointment. First one in my life. Listen.”

Under the flats, through the stones, out of the deep vault of the city, the Ninth Bell of Hollowmere began the hour again — the second ringing of the restored schedule, the ninth hour arriving on time for the first time in a hundred years — and I understood, in the way you understand a route’s last turn, what the Court had known when it stamped my petition with feeling. The bell does not only ring hours. It rings *appointments*. A scheduled death, announced, seen coming a long way off: the one kind of arithmetic that has never once failed to balance at that desk.

“Tell the Clerk,” said Bodkin, taking the needle-end of the anchor-thread up in his teeth the way we do, the way she taught us both from opposite sides of one lamp, “that the walk-in apologizes for the filing.”

And the ninth stroke came down, and on it, mirror-handed, in her exact stitch run the true way round, the first familiar of Elspeth Vane sewed himself into the bottom of the world.

I will not describe the working, and not because I cannot. It was the reverse of everything I had watched at the corner of the dream: not eight lights pulled out of a standing shape, but one light, going down the needle willingly, into the seam, whole — and the seam took it the way linen takes the last stitch of a shroud, and closed, and the singing stopped, and the whole length of her forty-year working pulled taut and true from the Wickhouse shore to the far fog with a sound like a kettle coming off the fire.

The flats settled. The Drowned, all across the mirror, stopped arriving — stood a moment, the way a page stands upright before it falls — and began, one by one, unhurried to the last, to *leave*: back down into a lake that was, for the first time in a century, only water on top. Deep under the glass, the patient one went down and down and away from the underside of the world with its promises voided and its down-payments — the Court’s foreclosure went through that same night; the auditors had the papers drawn before the bell finished striking; I am told the Mere is the first defendant in the Hollow Court’s history to be found in contempt *in absentia*, at the *bottom of itself* — with its down-payments ordered disgorged.

And on the black glass at the anchor of everything sat one cat, holding one strand of new grey stitching where an old grey tom had been, while the fog let go of the flats, and the ninth hour of the night came down over Hollowmere like a lamp being turned up, and out along the sea-wall, along the terraces, out of the fog and the years and the held dark under the water, the missing of the city began, in their coats and their feathers and their forty kinds of silence, to walk home.

Epilogue: Nine

The city took a season to walk all the way home, and I kept the accounts, because keeping accounts is most of what we do, between meals.

The Lamplighters came back over three weeks, in ones and twos, up out of the Mereside fog in their coats — their coats came to meet them; I watched it happen twice and will not try to write it better than it was — and the hall that had lit lamps at its own door every night of the long silence was, both times, exactly as bright as it had promised to be. Merrow chalked no marks for the returns. The tally on the hall door was rounds completed *until they walk back in*, and they walked back in, and she washed the door herself, one bucket, no speech, and started a new count at nothing, which is the correct number for a guild with nobody missing. The man whose empty coat I once walked home found it on its peg. I was on the wall opposite, as it happens, the way I happen to be on a number of walls. Nobody says anything. Everybody sees.

The child of the sunday jacket walked home in the third week, out of the fog at the sea-wall, to the one who had waited there at every dusk. And one coat stays on its peg: a fisherman's oilskin at the Wickhouse, older than living memory — the Mere's escrow reached back only so far, and it reached shorter for every week the seam stood contested. I know which weeks were mine, and had the charge entered where I said it belonged: to me. Nobody claims it. Nobody moves it.

The roosts of the Mereside filled. The old blind postmaster of the dead rail lived to feel the boards drum again under a hundred returning feet, and held his counter through one glorious deafening re-founding parliament, and died on his rail a month after, up to

his ears in gossip, on one foot, which among the Post is dying rich. The pigeon-net carried his name the whole length of the city twice. I heard it both times and both times it was said with the feathers up.

The Mere is water. I will not tell you it is only water — nothing in Hollowmere is only anything, and the seam is a seam still, wanting its maintenance, and maintenance is now among the duties of the estate I hold and answer for. But the fog keeps hours now. The Drowned have not been seen since the foreclosure. Day-side children have begun daring each other to swim off the sea-wall again, which the Court of Whiskers considers a deplorable development and I consider the whole point of everything.

And the city has its ninth hour back. Every night, over the roofs, the full count — one to nine, dropped into the dark like coins into a well, the ninth stroke deep and certain — and for one hour after it, an hour no living Hollowmere had ever kept before this year, the town lies open under the moon in a wash of unspent light. Nobody works the ninth hour; it will not hold a contract; the Horologists tried to meter it and their instruments returned, all together, a reading the Society has framed and hung in the tower stair: *paid in full*. People sleep differently. You can see it in their faces at the fish market: the dreams run to the end now. The whole city, every night, finally finishing its sentence.

The case closed the way cases close below: on paper. I attended. The Clerk read the finding into the record — the murder of Elspeth Vane, called the Needle; the murderer identified, deceased, *by appointment*; the file of the deceased murderer examined and found, after forty years of irregularity, to reconcile exactly — one life allotted at the last, one spent, ledger closed — and he stamped it, paw print, with feeling, and then he did a thing that is not in any form. He took the thick folder marked IRREGULAR, my folder, the season's whole appalling arithmetic of refusals and mendings and walk-ins, and he retired it *unresolved* — carried it himself down the corridor of shelves to the deep stacks where the finished centuries sleep, and shelved it, and stood a moment with his hand on the ribbon.

"I do not write fiction, as a rule," he said. "But I have come to believe the rule admits of a footnote."

The cat-sized chair is still at the desk. I have seven lives banked and no appointments posted, and a standing arrangement to take

tea — the Court takes tea; it is terrible tea; attendance is not about the tea — at the turning of each season, at which the Clerk reports, with professional disapproval and personal relish, on the continuing failure of my file to generate work. Somewhere in the deep stacks there is a second folder, a thin one, opened new this spring, and I have seen the cover, because he wanted me to see it. It says: *VANE, A. — heir. Active.*

Mistress Shear left the Circuit's candidacy and apprenticed herself, at her own petition, to Mother Cardew, who accepted her with the observation that wanting had always been the first qualification for the work, provided it finishes growing up. The ninth seat stays empty — the Needle's seat; the Circuit has stopped speaking of filling it and speaks now of *minding* it. And Cardew has taken down the two old stitcher-files — the Tatterstage lead among them: she signed the closings forty years ago; she signs the reopenings now.

Brindle fenced the gull feather from my board, at my instruction, for one button of ordinary brass, and we both recorded the transaction as *sentimental, non-precedential*. The thimble sits on her counting-board still, redeemed and un-redeemed, on permanent exhibition under the only sign in the Exchange: NOT FOR SALE. She holds that grief fences badly but exhibits well. She is right about everything; it is her one flaw.

The Quiet Gentleman has not called his knot. He will. Some evening years from now, at the worst possible hour, fog-smelling paper will come under a door I am behind, and the house's price will be named, and I will pay it, because I was taught by professionals: an account is a relationship, and his is the oldest relationship this city has, and even he — I have the Tatterstage's word for it, and she was precise — even he keeps some accounts for no reason money knows. On the anniversary of the water, every year, one vial of escrow-grade tears goes down to the tide with no name on the docket. The tide, which has never been bribed, takes it anyway.

Sootbeard was recommissioned by ordinance this autumn — a real one, sealed. Watch-monument, First Class, of the corner of Old Counting Row; regiment of one; reports received quarterly. The report is always the same — street secure, log complete, no unknowns — and he delivers it as if each word cost granite, and I receive it as if each word were owed, because it is.

Tansy can stitch.

I did not teach her — I issued no such appointment. She watched. From in front, from my lap-side, evening after evening while I maintain the estate's wards, with her chin on my foreleg and her whole absurd orange conviction fixed on the needle coming toward her — and one night in the spring I found the hem of the parlor curtain mended, badly, gloriously, in my own stitch, *run the true way round*. Mirror of a mirror. Her hand is her own entirely. She has announced that she is my apprentice; the Court of Whiskers has minuted it; I have given up litigating my own household, which is, Cardew informs me, the traditional first symptom of running one.

The Fish-Giver feeds the strays at dawn. Eleven years, now twelve. He still calls me puss. Long may he.

Two entries stay open. The chest-ledger still has no sentence that holds the woman at the window and the woman on the water; the page is still blank, and the estate has ruled it stays open — some seams are finished open. And the Remembered Day the Toll took stays taken. I keep her window every evening, and the one memory that would explain the keeping is not a place I can go and sit. The fact is mine, in my own handwriting. The warmth of it is at the Hollow Court.

And the house on Needle Lane is warm.

That is the entry I have been walking the whole ledger toward, so let me close the book properly, the way she would, with the accounts in order and the sequence minded. The threads are back on the workroom walls — not hers; hers went where they went, and the walls carry mine now, and Tansy's one glorious bad hem, and room for forty years more. The board over the mantel is empty. I unpinned it exhibit by exhibit on the night the file was retired, in reverse order of acquisition, the way you unpick a seam you are proud of, and the last thing off it was the first thing on: a candle stub, stamped with a bee, which I carried down to the tide myself.

The kettle sits on the hearthstone. It is used — Tansy takes milk warm; the Understudy was right about everything except whom the management deserved; guests come, on the ninth hour mostly, rats and birds and lamplighters and once, magnificently scandalizing the lane, a gargoyle as far as the window — and every time it boils, it boils for someone, and it has not screamed once since the night it

screamed, because there is always somebody in this house to take it off the fire in time. One paw. One try, these days. Everybody knows.

I sit at her window in the evenings, on the sill, under the lamps going up one by one like the city buttoning its coat. Fifteen years I was the one coming home to it, and I never once saw what she was looking at, all those evenings, coming to the glass at the sound of a drainpipe. Now I keep the window and I know. The lane fills at dusk. The Lamplighters walk their order past the gate, and the third lamp goes up, then the first, then the one by the pump, a signature signed correctly on the dark. The dog at Number Twelve barks at all of it, on schedule, with his whole heart, and the roosts over the lane conduct their parliament, and somewhere under everything a desk-lamp burns over a thin active folder, and out over the chimneys the ninth bell drops its deep stroke down through the moonlight — thread that has not been used yet, the whole sky of it, that can still become any stitch at all.

She always came to the window. I always thought it was for me.

It was for all of it. The entire salvage: every lamp, every bell, every fed stray and mended hem and small ridiculous rescued evening of this unpicked and re-sewn city — that is what stood at the glass every dusk of my life, wearing a red kerchief, counting what it held together. I know, because it is what stands here now, wearing the same one.

I am a cat somebody was expecting, once, every evening, for fifteen years.

Now I am the one expecting. The lamps are going up. The kettle is on.

Come home.

— *Ashcat, of Needle Lane*
called the Needle's heir
nine lives allotted, two spent, seven held
in trust